

CITY: PG 3

Rain wins the air, loses the roads



NATION: PG 5

NCERT tweaks Cong position on Partition



EXCLUSIVE: PG 7

'Delhi Deserves Solutions, Not Excuses'



Trump says interim ceasefire pact with Iran over, warns Tehran of fresh strikes

IRAN RETALIATES WITH MISSILE STRIKES TARGETING US MILITARY SITES IN BAHRAIN AND KUWAIT

ASSOCIATED PRESS

DUBAI: US President Donald Trump said on Wednesday that the interim agreement with Iran is "over" but he will allow talks to continue.

"For me, I think it's over," Trump responded when asked about the status of ceasefire. "It's just a waste of time dealing with them."

He made the comment on the sidelines of the two-day NATO summit in Ankara, Turkey, and hours after striking Iran in what the US described as retaliation for strikes on tankers in the Strait of Hormuz.

Trump threatened to attack Iran "hard" hours after saying he thinks the US-Iran ceasefire is "over". Trump - who is at the Nato summit in Turkey - earlier said of the Iranian leadership, "I don't want to deal with them anymore; they're scum." They're sick people; they're led



by sick people."

An Iranian official said Trump's comments drive "the region toward fire" - and

warned Iran's proxies in the region have their "finger on the triggers".

The US launched strikes

on Iran early Wednesday, hours after it revoked a license authorising the sale of Iranian oil in retaliation for what it said

CLOSER LOOK

» Iran warns Trump's remarks are pushing the region toward a wider conflict

» US military says strikes targeted Iranian air defenses, radars and Guard speedboats

» Washington says operation imposed costs for attacks on commercial shipping

» Iran reports explosions near Bandar Mahshahr and Bushehr nuclear power plant

» US says forces remain ready if Iran violates the interim agreement

» Iran insists it will not bow, says bullying and extortion will fail

India calls for restraint in West Asia amid rising tensions

SIMONTINI BHATTACHARJEE

NEW DELHI: India on Wednesday expressed deep concern over the rapidly deteriorating security situation in West Asia after a fresh wave of attacks on commercial shipping in the Strait of Hormuz that have considerably escalated regional tensions.

In a statement, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said the recent developments pose a serious threat to regional peace, security and stability, while also jeopardising the uninterrupted

Continued on P4

RAINFALL DEFICIT NARROWED TO 12%

Delhi, Mumbai grapple with monsoon havoc



One killed, around five feared trapped in Delhi's Rohini building collapse

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Heavy monsoon rains lashed large parts of India on Wednesday, triggering flash floods, landslides, building collapses and widespread disruption to road, rail and air transport, as rescue teams battled multiple emergencies across several states. In Maharashtra's Pimpri Chinchwad, at least 16 people were feared trapped after a massive garbage mound collapsed onto a three-storey building. In Delhi, one person died and several others were trapped when an under-construction building collapsed in Rohini amid heavy rain. The downpour also flooded roads in Mumbai, Delhi and Gurugram, disrupted train services across Maharashtra and Gujarat, and prompted the Centre to review the country's monsoon preparedness as rainfall activity intensified.

Union Home Minister Amit Shah spoke with the chief ministers of Kerala, Maharashtra, Gujarat and Jammu and Kashmir to assess the rain-related situation and assured them of all possible assistance from the Centre, officials said. The discussions followed a series of incidents, including the debris collapse at a tunnel project in Kerala's Wayanad, flash floods

TAKEAWAYS

» Massive rescue operations continued in Pimpri Chinchwad, Rohini and Wayanad

» Amit Shah reviewed rain situation with four chief ministers, assured central assistance

» Five people remained missing after Wayanad tunnel project debris collapse

» Delhi rain flooded roads, disrupted traffic; IMD issued red and orange alerts

» Gurugram waterlogging stalled vehicles and slowed traffic on major roads

» Centre reviewed El Nino preparedness, agriculture, reservoirs, health and essential supplies

in Jammu's Doda district and widespread disruptions reported from Maharashtra and Gujarat.

In Pimpri Chinchwad's Moshi area, a huge mound of garbage crashed onto a three-storey structure used as the administrative office of a private company handling waste on behalf of the civic body. A senior official said at least 16 people were feared trapped beneath the debris as rescue teams rushed to the site.

Continued on P4

Stock markets slump over 2%, oil prices jump more than 6%

MUMBAI: Equity markets slumped and oil prices jumped on Wednesday after US President Donald Trump declared the interim agreement with Iran was "over," while saying talks could continue. The BSE Sensex fell 1,677.12 points, or 2.15 per cent, to 76,503.60, and the NSE Nifty lost 516.65 points, or 2.12 per cent, to 23,882.05. Brent crude climbed over 6 per cent to about \$78.8 a barrel after US strikes on Iran and attacks on ships in the Strait of Hormuz. The rupee weakened 59 paise to 95.55 against the dollar as investors shifted to risk-off mode amid geopolitical uncertainty.

See P10

India, Indonesia launch UNESCO temple restoration as Modi heads to Australia



Prime Minister Narendra Modi being welcomed by members of the Indian community on his arrival, in Melbourne, Australia PTI

MPOST BUREAU

YOGYAKARTA: Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Indonesian President Prabowo Subianto on Wednesday inaugurated a joint conservation and restoration project at the UNESCO World Heritage-listed Prambanan Temple complex in Yogyakarta before Modi travelled to Australia for the second leg of his three-nation tour. Calling the initiative a symbol of the deep civilisational ties between India and Indonesia, Modi said preserving the centuries-old temple was about safeguarding traditions that continue to inspire future generations. Later in the day, he arrived in Melbourne for talks with Australian Prime Minister Anthony Albanese aimed at strengthening the India Australia Comprehensive Strategic Partnership.

The Prambanan Temple complex, built in the 9th century and located about 17 kilometres northeast of Yogyakarta, is Indonesia's largest Hindu temple and the country's biggest temple complex dedicated to the Trimurti of Lord Brahma, Lord Vishnu and Lord Shiva. The Ministry of External Affairs said the monument stands as an enduring symbol of the shared cultural and civilisational heritage between India and Indonesia.

The inauguration followed the exchange of a Letter of Intent between the two countries a day earlier to begin conservation and restoration work at the temple with Indian assistance. The Archaeological Survey of India will lead the project from the Indian side.

Unveiling a commemorative plaque with President Prabowo,

Continued on P4

US CHARGES BISHNOI, BRAR FOR NIJJAR'S KILLING

No evidence linking Indian govt to Nijjar killing, Canadian police contradict Trudeau's allegations

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: Canadian investigators have found no evidence linking Indian government officials to the 2023 killing of Sikh separatist Hardeep Singh Nijjar, a senior police official said, directly contradicting allegations made by then Canadian prime minister Justin Trudeau that had triggered one of the worst diplomatic crises between India and Canada. The statement came shortly after US authorities charged jailed gangster Lawrence Bishnoi and his associate Satinderjeet Singh, also known as Goldy Brar, with directing Nijjar's assassination.

Speaking to CBC News, Royal Canadian Mounted Police

(RCMP) Deputy Commissioner Lisa Moreland said the investigation had not uncovered any proof of involvement by Indian officials.

"There's no evidence to suggest through this organised crime investigation and the charges and the indictment laid forward that Indian officials were charged or involved," she said while responding to a question about Trudeau's earlier allegations.

Moreland also said the Indian government cooperated with the investigation.

Trudeau had alleged weeks after Nijjar was shot dead outside a gurdwara in British Columbia in 2023 that there were credible allegations linking the Indian government to the killing. India

THERE'S NO EVIDENCE TO SUGGEST THROUGH THIS ORGANISED CRIME INVESTIGATION AND THE CHARGES AND THE INDICTMENT LAID FORWARD THAT INDIAN OFFICIALS WERE CHARGED OR INVOLVED

rejected the charge as "absurd" and accused Canada of allowing pro-Khalistani elements to operate from its soil, pushing bilateral ties to a low point.

The diplomatic standoff deepened in October 2024 when

India recalled its High Commissioner Sanjay Kumar Verma and five other diplomats after Ottawa attempted to link them to the Nijjar case. India also expelled an equal number of Canadian diplomats.

Relations began improving after Liberal Party leader Mark Carney won the parliamentary election in April last year. Both countries later restored their high commissioners and agreed to revive several bilateral mechanisms to strengthen cooperation in different sectors. The relationship received another boost following Prime Minister Carney's visit to India in March.

Commenting on the latest developments,

Continued on P4

SHARED HERITAGE



Prime Minister Narendra Modi, left, shakes hands with Indonesian President Prabowo Subianto during their visit at Prambanan Temple, in Yogyakarta, Indonesia, on Wednesday AP/PTI

Baruipur rape-murder accused killed in police encounter, fourth held

Firearms used by police will be sent for forensic examination

GOURAB NETO

KOLKATA: Over the past few days, the usually quiet town of Baruipur has been thrust into the spotlight following a series of shocking events. The area first witnessed the rape and murder of a minor, followed by public outrage that culminated in the lynching of a man. The horror took another turn on Wednesday when gunshots shattered the silence of Surjyapur shortly after midnight as one of the prime accused in the rape and murder case, allegedly snatched a policeman's service pistol and



Prabhas Mondal

tried to flee during a crime scene reconstruction. Prabhas Mondal was shot by the police moments later.

In another breakthrough, police, on Wednesday,

Police claimed Prabhas fired a round at the pursuing officers, following which Arghya Mondal, a plainclothes officer of Baruipur police station and another SIT member, fired two rounds

arrested the fourth accused, Kabir Molla, from Basirhat in North 24-Parganas. He had been absconding since the body of

Continued on P4

Jaishankar meets Kuwait's Crown Prince, discusses ways to enhance ties



MPOST BUREAU

KUWAIT CITY: External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar on Wednesday met Kuwait's Crown Prince Sheikh Sabah Al-Khaled Al-Sabah and the two leaders discussed ways to enhance the bilateral cooperation in various fields as well as developments in West Asia.

In a social media post, Jaishankar said he conveyed the greetings of Prime Minister Narendra Modi to the Crown Prince.

"Deeply appreciate his commitment to take forward our bilateral cooperation. Thank him for his sharing of perspectives on developments in the Gulf," the minister said.

In a post on X, the Kuwaiti Foreign Ministry said that the two leaders discussed historical ties between the two countries and ways to enhance bilateral cooperation in various fields.

Jaishankar also met his Kuwaiti counterpart Sheikh Jarrah Jaber Al-Ahmad Al-Sabah and discussed the impact of the Gulf conflict on the region and beyond.

He also conveyed his appreciation to the Kuwait foreign minister for

Continued on P4

CENTRE'S AISHE REPORT

Higher education enrolment rises by over 1 crore since 2014

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Higher education enrolment in India has increased by more than 1.08 crore since 2014-15, while female enrolment has risen by 42.2 per cent, according to the All India Survey on Higher Education (AISHE) reports for 2022-23 and 2023-24 released by the Ministry of Education on Wednesday.

The reports show that total enrolment grew from 3.42 crore in 2014-15 to 4.46 crore in 2022-23 and further to 4.50 crore in 2023-24, marking a 31.5 per cent increase over the decade.

KEY POINTS

» Total enrolment rose by over 1.08 crore since 2014-15.

» Overall higher education enrolment increased 31.5 per cent over the decade.

» Female enrolment reached 2.24 crore in 2023-24.

» Female enrolment increased 42.2 per cent since 2014-15.

» SC student enrolment rose to 69.72 lakh in 2023-24.

» ST student enrolment climbed to 28.83 lakh, up 75.7 per cent.

» OBC enrolment reached 1.80 crore in 2023-24.

» STEM enrolment increased to 1.02 crore from 91.5 lakh.

Female enrolment also recorded steady growth, rising from 1.57 crore in 2014-15 to 2.18 crore in 2022-23 and 2.24

crore in 2023-24. "It is commendable increase in female enrolment in higher education," the report said.

The survey also recorded higher participation from students belonging to Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes and Other Backward Classes. Enrolment of SC students increased from 46.07 lakh in 2014-15 to 69.72 lakh in 2023-24, a rise of 51.4 per cent. ST enrolment grew from 16.41 lakh to 28.83 lakh during the same period, an increase of 75.7 per cent. OBC student enrolment rose from 1.13 crore to

Continued on P4

Court orders action after cops treat murder as road accident

Probe lapses led to loss of crucial evidence; police chief directed to examine inquiry personally

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A court here has pulled up the Delhi Police for allegedly treating a case of “brutal and deliberate murder” as a road accident and directed the police commissioner to initiate disciplinary action against the officials responsible for serious lapses in the probe.

Judicial Magistrate First Class Bharti Beniwal was hearing a plea seeking monitoring of the investigation into the death of Chandresh alias Monu, who succumbed to injuries after remaining hospitalised for 22 days. The judicial magistrate said that the case raised a “disturbing question” as to how allegations of a deliberate murder were sought to be converted into an accidental narrative by the police.

In an order dated June 29, the court said, “Such a lapse is bound to have a serious adverse impact on the prosecution’s case during trial. This is not



a mere procedural irregularity but a fundamental defect that goes to the very root of the matter and warrants appropriate departmental action against the erring officials.”

According to the complaint, the victim had named Nager as his assailant and alleged that he was assaulted and run over by a vehicle in an attempt to kill him. His family also submitted a video in which the injured man allegedly identified the accused.

CLOSER LOOK

- » ‘Such a lapse is bound to have a serious adverse impact on the prosecution’s case during trial. This is not a mere procedural irregularity but a fundamental defect that goes to the very root of the matter and warrants appropriate departmental action against the erring officials’
- » According to the complaint, the victim had named Nager as his assailant and alleged that he was assaulted and run over by a vehicle in an attempt to kill him. His family also submitted a video in which the injured man allegedly identified the accused

The case was registered in the Shahbad Diary police station against the accused.

The court said it was difficult to understand why the FIR was initially registered under provisions relating to rash and negligent driving despite specific allegations of assault and attempted murder. It noted there was no material in the complaint suggesting the incident was a mere accident.

“Such independent scrutiny is necessary to ensure that

tim’s recorded statement, which prima facie bore the character of a dying declaration.

“The record discloses a grave lapse on the part of the IO (investigation officer) and the SHO (station house officer) in conducting a prompt and effective investigation. As a result, vital material evidence, which was available at the initial stage, has not been properly collected and preserved and now stands irretrievably lost,” the court said.

The court also noted that an existing forensic opinion indicating an assault was ignored in the supervisory report.

Holding that vital evidence had been lost due to investigative lapses, the court directed the police commissioner to examine the matter personally and take appropriate disciplinary action against the IO, SHO and other responsible officers.

It also sought a compliance report and listed the matter for July 13.

2020 DELHI RIOTS

Delhi court fags police witness delays & wastage of court time

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A court here has expressed concern over repeated delays in the appearance of police witnesses and the production of case property in a case related to the 2020 Delhi riots, saying it resulted in wastage of time.

Additional Sessions Judge Parveen Singh also directed that the issue be brought to the notice of the police commissioner so that the timely presence of police witnesses before trial courts could be ensured.

In an order dated July 7, the court said, “It has been observed that police witnesses are not present before this court at 10 am and usually they appear at 11 am which results in wastage of that much time. Most of the cases in this court are at the stage of evidence and therefore, call for evidence case usually comes at around 10.05 am.”

The judge further said that the delay had continued despite a similar concern having already been recorded in the previous hearing.



KEY POINTS

- » ‘It has been observed that police witnesses are not present before this court at 10 am and usually they appear at 11 am which results in wastage of that much time’: Court stated
- » ‘Most of the cases in this court are at the stage of evidence and therefore, call for evidence case usually comes at around 10.05 am’

The order came after the matter was called twice but

the court was informed that the case property had not been produced by the police. The court later noted that the concerned official of the Special Cell appeared only at 10.55 am, by then testimony in another case had already commenced. It also noted that the investigating officer in that matter had arrived late.

Directing that a copy of its July 4 order be annexed, the court said the matter should be brought to the notice of the Delhi police commissioner “to look into the issue and to ensure the presence of witnesses before the court in time.”

“Let the matter be brought to the notice of Worthy Commissioner of Police to look into the issue and to ensure the presence of witnesses before the court in time. Copy of the order dated July 4, 2026 be also annexed with this order,” it said.

The court was hearing a case against multiple persons who were accused of rioting, unlawful assembly and being part of riots in the Dayalpur area of the national capital.

WEST DELHI’S HARI NAGAR

Woman dies after setting herself ablaze, jumping from third floor

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A 23-year-old woman died after allegedly setting herself on fire and jumping from the third floor of her residence in west Delhi’s Hari Nagar area on Wednesday, an official said.

According to the police, preliminary inquiry suggested that she had been under stress due to matrimonial issues and concerns over the custody of her child.

Police received a call reporting that a woman had jumped from the third floor of a building while engulfed in flames. A police team rushed to the scene, but she had already been taken to Deen Dayal Upadhyay Hospital by locals.

The woman, identified as Laxmi, was declared brought dead at the hospital, police said.

“Laxmi’s father, Jahan Singh, told investigators that she had married Rajender and the couple has a son. Matrimo-



“She’d been under considerable stress, particularly regarding the care and custody of her child”

nal disputes arose between the two in 2023, following which Laxmi had been living with her father at a house in Hari Nagar,” a senior police officer said.

She had been employed at a clothing store in Uttam Nagar but had left her job four to five days before the incident, according to her father’s statement.

Minor collision leads to scuffle inside Dwarka e-way tunnel

NEW DELHI: A minor collision between two vehicles escalated into a scuffle inside the Dwarka Expressway tunnel after one of the drivers allegedly attempted to assault the other with a stick, police said on Wednesday.

The incident was reported to the police control room in southwest Delhi at 7.44 pm on Tuesday. The caller alleged that his car brushed against a taxi inside the tunnel, following which the taxi driver allegedly tried to attack him with a stick.

The caller told police that when he pushed the taxi driver in self-defence, he allegedly fell onto an SUV, causing minor damage to the vehicle. The SUV owner then stopped the caller and sought compensation for the damage, while the taxi driver fled the scene.

“PCR personnel who reached the spot found that the taxi driver had already escaped.

The caller and the SUV owner resolved the issue amicably at the spot, and no one sustained any injuries in the incident,” a senior police officer said.

He said a Kapashera Police team visited the location but found neither damaged vehicles nor injured persons. During a telephonic conversation, the caller told police that he had returned home, the matter was settled mutually, and he did not wish to initiate legal proceedings. Police said efforts are underway to identify the taxi driver. CCTV footage from the Dwarka Expressway tunnel and nearby areas is being examined to establish the sequence of events and ascertain the taxi driver’s identity, they said. Meanwhile, a purported video of the incident, showing the taxi driver trying to hit the man with a stick even as he tries to save himself, has gone viral. MPOST



As part of Child Safety Awareness Month, Delhi Police Public School, Safdarjung Enclave, held an awareness programme on Wednesday, with the principal stressing child safety and the school’s commitment to a secure, nurturing environment MPOST

New DCPCR Chairperson takes charge, meets CM Rekha Gupta

AIMAN FATIMA



NEW DELHI: With the Delhi government intensifying its focus on child protection, newly appointed Delhi Commission for Protection of Child Rights (DCPCR) Chairperson Om Prakash Vyas assumed charge on Wednesday and met Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, signalling a renewed push to strengthen child safety mechanisms, enforce the POCSO Act and build a more accountable child protection system across the national capital.

Soon after taking charge, Vyas paid a courtesy visit to the Chief Minister, where the two discussed issues concerning children’s rights, safety and holistic development. Congratulating him, Gupta said the Delhi government’s commitment to protecting children remains unwavering.

“Protecting children’s rights and safeguarding their welfare remains the Delhi Government’s highest priority,” the Chief Minister said. She added

that under the Commission’s new leadership, it would function with “sensitivity, transparency and accountability” and help create “a safe, dignified and trustworthy environment for children across the Capital.”

Gupta also highlighted that the recently launched Child Protection Month has directed all concerned departments to ensure effective implementation of the POCSO Act, establish Child Protection Committees in schools, conduct awareness campaigns and strengthen institutional mecha-

nisms for child safety. She said the Commission would play a crucial role in taking these initiatives forward.

After assuming office, Vyas said the Commission would work in line with the Chief Minister’s vision for child welfare. “Chief Minister Rekha Gupta has a clear and sensitive vision for protecting children’s rights, ensuring their welfare and promoting their holistic development. This vision will guide the Commission’s work,” he said.

He further added, “All members of the Commission are committed to working round the clock to protect children’s rights, secure their future and support their overall development.”

Vyas said the Commission would work closely with the Education Department, the Department of Women and Child Development, Delhi Police and other institutions to ensure effective implementation of child rights laws and prompt action on child safety issues. He also identified safe school environments, stronger Child Protection Committees, awareness on safe and unsafe touch, cyber safety, gender sensitisation and personal safety as key priorities.

A former Chairperson of the Child Welfare Committee in Delhi and former Joint Registrar (Law) at the National Human Rights Commission, Vyas has over 27 years of experience in human rights and law enforcement and is a recipient of the President’s Police Medal for meritorious service.

DDA unveils online application process for TOD projos

SHIVANGI SHUKLA

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Development Authority (DDA) has opened the application process for Developer Entities (DEs) seeking to develop their land under the revised Transit-Oriented Development (TOD) Policy through the Online Building Permit System (OBPS), marking a key step towards implementing the capital’s revamped transit-linked urban planning framework.

Framed under the guidance of Lieutenant Governor Sardar Taranjit Singh Sandhu, the revised policy requires Developer Entities to first obtain sanction of TOD plots from the TOD Committee by applying through DDA’s OBPS. Once the plots are approved, building plans for TOD projects must also be submitted through the same online platform for DDA’s clearance. The authority has launched a dedicated microsite on its website to facilitate all matters related to the imple-

‘Revised policy seeks to improve ease of doing business by introducing a simplified single-window clearance mechanism via TOD’

mentation of the TOD Policy. The revised policy seeks to improve ease of doing business by introducing a simplified single-window clearance

mechanism through the TOD Committee, chaired by the DDA Vice-Chairman and comprising representatives from all key stakeholder and service-providing agencies. It also introduces a single TOD charge covering water and sewerage, building plan approval, change of land use, levies, additional Floor Area Ratio (FAR), and conversion of leasehold properties to freehold.

Adopting a corridor-based approach, the policy covers 207 sq km along Metro cor-

ridors and around Regional Rapid Transit System (RRTS) and railway stations, including nearly 80 sq km of land previously excluded. It permits TOD projects on plots of 2,000 sq m and above, allows a maximum FAR of 500, mandates at least 65 per cent residential use to promote affordable housing, and provides flexibility for commercial and mixed-use development while improving pedestrian connectivity to transit stations and strengthening public infrastructure.

HIGHLIGHTS GAINS IN JOBS, GENDER INDICATORS, WELFARE

Report: City registers decline in poverty and unemployment rate in recent years

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The proportion of people living in poverty in Delhi decreased from 4.4 per cent to 3.21 per cent, while the unemployment rate dropped from 9.7 per cent to 2.1 per cent in recent years, according to a recent status report.

The Delhi State Indicator Framework (SIF) 2025 report, released recently by the Directorate of Economics and Statistics, tracks sustainable development goals (SDGs) progress at the state level.

This report facilitates decision-making and supports the implementation of government schemes, covering Delhi’s progress on 16 SDGs. It states that the proportion of people, including men, women, and



children, living in poverty fell from 4.4 per cent in 2015-16 to 2.1 per cent in 2017-18.

The “No Poverty” SDG aims to eliminate poverty in all its forms. The report also points out that the number of beneficiaries under the “Women in Distress” scheme in Delhi increased from 168,977 in 2015-16 to 197,863 in 2017-

“Female labour force participation rate rose from 11.2% in 2017-18 to 13.7% in 2018-19, 14.5% in 2023-24”

18, 238,706 in 2019-20, 312,272 in 2021-22, and 397,465 in 2024-25.

The report, based on the United Nations (UN) “Transforming Our World: the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development”, highlights improvements in Delhi’s sex ratio over the past decade.

The sex ratio at birth

(number of female live births per 1,000 male live births) increased from 898 in 2015 to 913 in 2017, 920 in 2019, 929 in 2022, and back to 920 in 2024.

Additionally, the female labour force participation rate rose from 11.2 per cent in 2017-18 to 13.7 per cent in 2018-19, and further to 14.5 per cent in 2023-24.

According to the report, Delhi’s unemployment rate was 9.7 per cent in 2017-18, gradually decreasing to 8.7 per cent in 2019-20, 5.3 per cent in 2021-22, and finally to 2.1 per cent in 2023-24.

The labour force participation rate for individuals aged 15 to 59 years was 49.9 per cent in 2017-18 and increased to 51.5 per cent in 2023-24, as noted in the report.

Delhi Police traces 6 missing persons

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police Crime Branch has traced and reunited six missing persons, including minors, young adults and an unidentified body linked to a missing person case, under its ongoing Operation Milap.

The recoveries were made by the Anti-Human Trafficking Units (AHTU) of Northern Range-I and Northern Range-II during coordinated operations across Delhi and Haryana.

Among those traced were two missing girls carrying rewards of Rs 20,000 each, an especially able young man missing for over two years, an 11-year-old boy, and a 14-year-old girl reported missing from Paschim Vihar on July 1. Police located the minor in Seemapuri within two days using technical

surveillance and local enquiries. She later told investigators she had travelled with a friend without informing her family.

In another case, an 18-year-old girl missing from Rohini since December 2025 and another 19-year-old woman from Alipur were traced in Haryana and West Delhi, respectively.

Police also reunited a mentally ill and speech-impaired 21-year-old man with his family after identifying him through photographs circulated among shelter homes and social media groups. An unidentified body was also identified through verification of a UIDB entry linked to an ongoing investigation.

Police said all recovered persons have been handed over to the respective investigating officers for further legal proceedings.

Ridge logs 154% excess July rain; cleanest air in over 10 months comes with waterlogging, traffic snarls

Rain wins the air, loses the roads

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi's Ridge weather station recorded 154 per cent excess rainfall in July, and the capital registered its cleanest air in more than 10 months on Wednesday, even as waterlogging and traffic snarls disrupted normal life.

According to the India Meteorological Department (IMD), the Ridge weather station received 79.1 mm of rainfall between July 1 and 8.30 am on July 8, 154 per cent higher than the long-period average of 31.2 mm for the corresponding period.

The rain led to waterlogging and traffic congestion across several parts of the city. Long queues of vehicles were seen on Rohtak Road, where traffic was almost brought to a standstill between Punjabi Bagh and Shadipur for several hours. The situation worsened as several two-wheeler riders took shelter under elevated Metro corridors, creating bottlenecks.

Traffic congestion was also reported at the ITO intersection. Commuters faced delays on Ring Road, Outer Ring Road and National Highway 48, particularly near Dhaula Kuan, Mahipalpur and Rajokri due to reduced visibility and waterlogging.

Vehicular movement was also affected on Mathura road near Ashram, the Delhi-Gurgaon Expressway, Zakkhira flyover, Moti Nagar, Patel Nagar, Naraina, AIIMS, South Extension, Lajpat Nagar, Moolchand, Azadpur, Mukarba Chowk and stretches of the Delhi-Noida



Vehicles wade through a waterlogged road after heavy rainfall, at Ghazipur in New Delhi, Wednesday PTI

Link Road. Traffic police personnel were deployed at major intersections to regulate traffic and clear congestion, while civic agencies worked to drain water from affected stretches. Authorities advised commuters to avoid waterlogged routes, maintain a safe distance between vehicles and check traffic updates before heading out. The city's 24-hour average Air Quality Index (AQI) stood at 59 in the 'satisfactory' category, the lowest since September 4, 2025, when it was 58. According to the Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB), an AQI between 0 and 50 is considered 'good', while 51-100 falls in the 'satisfactory' category.

The weather office said cumulative rainfall till 8.30 am stood at 14.2 mm at Safdarjung, 19.2 mm at Palam, 17.8 mm at

Lodhi Road, 54.3 mm at Ridge, 37.6 mm at Ayanagar, 18.6 mm at Rajghat, 44.5 mm at Pusa, 85.5 mm at Najafgarh and 24.5 mm at Mayur Vihar.

Between 8.30 am and 5.30 pm, Safdarjung received 26.0 mm of rainfall, Palam 27.9 mm, Lodhi Road 30.0 mm, Ridge 11.8 mm, Ayanagar 22.2 mm, Rajghat 10.1 mm, Pusa 30.5 mm, Najafgarh 38.0 mm and Mayur Vihar 26.5 mm.

Till 5.30 pm, cumulative rainfall stood at 40.2 mm at Safdarjung, 47.1 mm at Palam, 47.8 mm at Lodhi Road, 66.1 mm at Ridge, 59.8 mm at Ayanagar, 28.7 mm at Rajghat, 75.0 mm at Pusa, 123.5 mm at Najafgarh and 51.0 mm at Mayur Vihar.

Delhi's civic bodies received at least 10 complaints of rain-

related waterlogging, tree falls and electricity disruptions during the day.

The Municipal Corporation of Delhi's Central Control Room received eight complaints between 2 pm and 6 pm, including four related to tree falls and four for waterlogging.

The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) separately reported two complaints of waterlogging till the afternoon from Malcha Marg Market in Chanakypuri and Kartavya Bhawan on Janpath, in front of the National Archaeological building. It also received 15 complaints related to power disruptions, of which seven had been resolved, while eight were under process and one had been reopened. Three complaints of tree falls were also

HIGHLIGHTS

- » The Municipal Corporation of Delhi's Central Control Room received eight complaints between 2 pm and 6 pm, including 4 related to tree falls and 4 for waterlogging
- » The rain led to waterlogging and traffic congestion across several parts of the city
- » The Delhi government has deployed 200 teams across the city to tackle waterlogging as part of its monsoon preparedness plan

reported in the NDMC area. The persistent showers kept temperatures well below normal across the city. Safdarjung recorded a maximum temperature of 30.8 degrees Celsius, 5.8 notches below normal, followed by Palam at 30.0 degrees Celsius, 7.4 notches below normal, Lodhi Road at 30.2 degrees Celsius, 4.8 notches below normal, Ridge at 29.4 degrees Celsius, 6.8 notches below normal, and Ayanagar at 28.3 degrees Celsius, 8.3 notches below normal.

Several areas, including Sadar Bazar, Nasirpur, Greater Kailash, Badarpur, Teliwara, Mahavir Bazar, Swarup Nagar and Kushak Road, among others, were waterlogged. Pedestrians were seen wading through knee-high water at some places. The minimum tempera-

ture also remained below normal. Safdarjung recorded 25.4 degrees Celsius, 2.5 notches below normal with 100 pc of relative humidity, Palam 23.4 degrees Celsius, 4.8 notches below normal, Lodhi Road 25.2 degrees Celsius, 1.8 notches below normal, Ridge 22.1 degrees Celsius, 4.3 notches below normal, and Ayanagar 24.3 degrees Celsius, 2.4 notches below normal. Mahesh Palawat, vice president (Meteorology and Climate Change), Sky-met Weather, said the ongoing spell of rain is due to the seasonal monsoon trough shifting northwards.

"The seasonal trough, previously positioned over central India, is gradually shifting northwards to the Himalayan foothills. It will pass through Delhi but is not expected to remain there. The rain is due to the fact that the trough is passing through the national capital. It is currently over southwest Uttar Pradesh and the southern parts of Delhi, so such rains will continue for the next few days," he said.

"Once the trough settles along the foothills, Jammu and Kashmir, Himachal Pradesh and other Himalayan regions will receive enhanced rainfall. The western end of the trough will lie along the foothills, while the eastern end will extend over eastern Uttar Pradesh and Bihar. These regions will continue to receive rainfall, whereas Delhi, Haryana, Rajasthan and adjoining northwestern parts are likely to experience a break monsoon phase with comparatively dry weather," Palawat said.



Ggm at standstill

OUR CORRESPONDENT

GURUGRAM: Over 115 mm of rainfall was recorded in Gurugram during the last 33 hours, causing waterlogging in several parts of the city and widespread traffic congestion on Wednesday.

According to official data, 83 mm of rainfall was recorded on Tuesday, followed by another 32 mm on Wednesday.

Waterlogging was reported from several areas, including Sectors 31, 39, 40, 44, 45, 46, 56 and 57, as well as Sheela Mata Mandir Road, Sector-10A, Sectors 14 and 15, Pataudi Road, Basai Road, Kadipur, Umang Bhardwaj Chowk, Basai and the service lane near Narsinghpur, Basai, Umang Bhardwaj Chowk, Kadipur and Sohna Road, with several vehicles reportedly breaking down in waterlogged stretches.

Officials said teams from the Municipal Corporation of Gurugram (MCG), Gurugram Metropolitan Development Authority (GMDA), police and other agencies were deployed to drain out water and regulate traffic.

A cyclist fell into a pit dug for a sewer line in Feroze Gandhi Colony, while a cow was injured after falling into another pit, locals said. A school bus also got stuck in a pit in the Rajendra Park area, they said.

Commuters said traffic congestion on several routes delayed their journey home by several hours. Long queues of vehicles were reported from the Delhi-Gurugram border to several internal roads of the city.

The India Meteorological Department (IMD) has forecast more rainfall over the next few days. Municipal Commissioner Pradeep Dahiya said the civic body had undertaken drainage improvement works ahead of the monsoon to address chronic waterlogging.

DPCC rolls out Dust Portal 2.0

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: All construction and demolition projects will be required to submit periodic compliance reports, install air quality sensors and provide live camera feeds for real-time monitoring under the Delhi Pollution Control Committee's (DPCC) upgraded Dust Portal 2.0.

In a bid to strengthen oversight of dust pollution from construction activities, the DPCC has issued a user manual for Dust Portal 2.0, an upgraded version of its Dust Pollution Control Self-Assessment Portal.

According to the user manual of the portal, all construction and demolition projects with a plot area of 500 square metres or more are required to register on the platform, which has been developed in line with directions issued by the Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM).

The portal aims to digitise compliance monitoring by enabling project proponents to self-register construction sites, map site boundaries using GIS technology, submit periodic self-audit reports and upload supporting documents and photographs. It also integrates real-time monitoring of PM2.5 and PM10 levels and live video surveillance of project sites.

Under the system, registered project proponents will have to submit a Self-Audit Assessment Sheet every 15 days. The audit covers 12 compliance parameters, including green net coverage around sites, water sprinkling, covering of construction material stockpiles, vehicle tyre-washing facilities, anti-smog gun installation, air quality sensors, CCTV surveillance, waste disposal and worker awareness programmes.

Specifications of camera installation and setup instructions have also been issued for construction sites to comply with.

The manual warns that incomplete or delayed submissions may attract show-cause notices from the DPCC.

A key feature of the portal is GIS-based mapping of construction sites. Existing users of the earlier DPCC portal

have been directed to complete a one-time migration process by digitally marking the exact boundaries of all previously registered projects before accessing the new dashboard.

The system also automatically calculates the number of anti-smog guns required at a site based on its built-up area. Projects with a built-up area between 5,000 and 10,000 square metres must install one anti-smog gun, while projects exceeding 20,000 square metres require four.

In addition, all registered construction sites are required to install PM2.5 and PM10 sensors for continuous air-quality monitoring and provide live CCTV feeds through RTSP links to enable remote surveillance by the pollution watchdog.

The portal also includes provisions for tracking compliance status, viewing departmental communications and responding to show-cause notices issued by the DPCC.

The DPCC has advised users to access the platform through Google Chrome or Microsoft Edge browsers and has provided technical support mechanisms, including OTP-based registration and password recovery systems.

Officials said the DUST Portal 2.0 represents a major step towards technology-driven environmental governance aimed at improving air quality and strengthening pollution control measures in Delhi.

Officials said the upgraded portal forms part of a broader push to improve compliance monitoring and reduce dust emissions from construction activities, which remain a significant contributor to air pollution in the national capital.

Earlier, officials had said that the portal will also integrate PM sensors, AI cameras and Continuous Ambient Air Quality Monitoring (CAAQM) stations to assess the impact of individual construction sites on PM2.5 and PM10 levels.

Officials had added that the platform will include a three-tier AI-based alert mechanism to ensure timely intervention.

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Chief Minister Rekha Gupta issued strict orders on Wednesday to combat the misuse of power of attorney for evading stamp duty.

She directed that every power of attorney document executed in favour of non-blood relations must be evaluated and decided upon within 30 days by the collectors of stamps in Delhi.

The move will curb revenue loss in the registration of immovable properties and also rein in land mafia and irregular practices at sub-registrar offices, the Delhi Chief Minister's Office said in a statement.

The General Power of Attorney (GPA) documents executed in favour of individuals other than blood relations, specifically parents, spouses, sons, daughters, brothers, or sisters, will no longer be directly registered by the sub-registrar.

"All such cases will be man-



datorily referred to the concerned collector of stamps for adjudication to determine the appropriate stamp duty payable," the chief minister said.

The collector of stamps will be required to pass a reasoned written order on every such reference within thirty days. The order will determine whether the document is merely a GPA or attracts full stamp duty as applicable to a conveyance deed

(sale deed), she said. In exceptional circumstances, this period may be extended up to a maximum of three months. No such GPA will be registered unless the collector of stamps has passed the order and the appropriate stamp duty has been paid, she said. Acting on the chief minister's directions, strict guidelines have been issued for the detailed scrutiny of property-related documents executed through GPA. All sub-registrars have been directed to ensure strict compliance with these instructions with immediate effect, the CMO said.

It has been observed that in several cases, documents are registered merely as a GPA by paying only a nominal stamp duty, even though they contain provisions relating to the sale of property, handing over possession and transfer of ownership rights. Chief Minister Gupta stated that this practice represents direct evasion of stamp

duty and will not be tolerated under any circumstances. She said that every GPA document presented for registration in Delhi will now undergo detailed scrutiny by the sub-registrars.

During the examination, particular attention will be paid to whether the document mentions any monetary consideration, provides for the handing over of possession of the property, is irrevocable in nature, or grants permanent authority to sell, gift, transfer, or mortgage the property, she said.

Gupta warned that strict disciplinary action would be taken against sub-registrars who register GPAs involving monetary gains. Every sub-registrar's office will maintain a separate register for such cases and submit monthly reports. The chief minister has also directed the development of an online tracking mechanism within a month to monitor these cases, as stated by the CMO.

MCD orders merger of 13 schools across 3 Delhi zones

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) has ordered the merger of 13 schools across three zones, including Karol Bagh, Narela and Shahdara North, with the exercise set to come into effect from the current academic session, according to an official order.

The order issued by the MCD Education Department on June 22, stated that administrative approval has been granted for the merger of the identified schools and directed the zonal Deputy Directors of Education (DDEs) and Assistant Directors of Education (ADEs) to complete the merger process and submit compliance reports by July 15.

The civic body has further asked zonal officials to submit proposals for the transfer or adjustment of staff, including principals, special educators, school attendants, Paryavaran Sahayaks and chowkidars who may become surplus following the merger.

Kejriwal residence may host guests

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government is considering converting the official residence occupied by former chief minister Arvind Kejriwal into a state guest house, according to a PTI report citing official sources.

The proposal pertains to bungalow number 6 on Flagstaff Road in Civil Lines, which has remained vacant since Kejriwal demitted office. If approved, the

property will be used to accommodate visiting ministers and government officials on a payment basis, similar to other state guest houses. According to officials, the proposed facility will include amenities such as a waiting hall, parking space and other essential infrastructure. The proposal is currently awaiting final clearance from the competent authorities. Officials also said that around 10 staff members are presently deployed

to maintain the bungalow. Their responsibilities include routine housekeeping and the upkeep of electrical equipment such as air conditioners and refrigerators to ensure the property remains functional. The government has explored multiple options over the past few months to repurpose the bungalow, which had become the centre of political controversy following its renovation during Kejriwal's tenure.

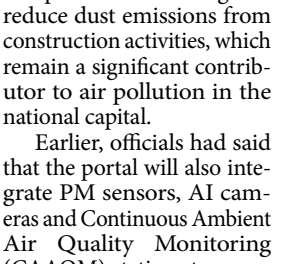
CEA, BSES HOLD NATIONAL ELECTRICAL SAFETY AWARENESS PROGRAMME

Electrical safety takes centre stage

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Central Electricity Authority (CEA), under the Ministry of Power, in collaboration with BSES discoms, organised the All-India Electrical Safety Awareness Programme on the occasion of Electrical Safety Day 2026 in New Delhi. More than 1,300 delegates from the power sector, fire services, industries, resident welfare associations (RWAs) and consumer groups attended the event, which was also live-streamed on YouTube and has garnered over 76,000 views.

The theme for this year's programme, "Today's Awareness, Tomorrow's Prevention: Let Us All Unite to Prevent Fire Hazards from Electrical Short Circuits," focused on promoting awareness to reduce electrical accidents and fire incidents. Speakers stressed that most electrical fires can be prevented through regular inspec-



tions, proper maintenance, safe usage practices, quality electrical equipment and responsible consumer behaviour.

In video messages, Union Power and Housing & Urban Affairs Minister Manohar Lal and Minister of State for Power and New & Renewable Energy

Shripad Yesso Naik urged citizens to make electrical safety a part of their daily routine. They emphasised the importance of regular safety check-ups, proper earthing, avoiding overloading of electrical circuits and using certified electrical equipment.

The event was attended by CEA Chairperson Ghanshyam Prasad, senior CEA members, Director General of Fire Services Sunil Kumar Jha, BSES Group CEO Amar Sinha, BRPL CEO Abhishek Ranjan, and BYPL COO Santosh Kumar, among other officials.

During the programme, CEA launched two publications, 'Vidyut SurSurakshadhi',

an electrical safety handbook for children, and the 'Electrical Fire Safety Book', aimed at spreading awareness on preventing electrical fire hazards.

Actor Ashutosh Rana delivered a keynote fireside talk highlighting the importance of prevention. Explaining the difference between protection and preparedness, he said, "Raksha is protection after a crisis, while Suraksha is the awareness and discipline that prevent a crisis from occurring." Drawing examples from Indian philosophy, he added that "power must always be accompanied by restraint, stability and responsibility."

During the programme, CEA launched two publications, 'Vidyut SurSurakshadhi', an electrical safety handbook for children, and the 'Electrical Fire Safety Book', aimed at spreading awareness on preventing electrical fire hazards.

Actor Ashutosh Rana delivered a keynote fireside talk highlighting the importance of prevention. Explaining the difference between protection and preparedness, he said, "Raksha is protection after a crisis, while Suraksha is the awareness and discipline that prevent a crisis from occurring." Drawing examples from Indian philosophy, he added that "power must always be accompanied by restraint, stability and responsibility."

Delhi, Mumbai grapple with monsoon havoc

Continued from Page 1

In Delhi, rescue operations continued late into the evening after an under-construction three-storey building collapsed near an MCD school in Sector 16 of Rohini at around 4.20 pm. One worker, identified as Ram, 42, died in the incident, while Saddam, 32, was pulled out alive and admitted to Babasaheb Ambedkar Hospital with fractures to his pelvis and arm. Hospital officials said his condition was stable.

Police said around five more people were still feared trapped beneath the rubble. Teams from the Delhi Police, Delhi Fire Service, National Disaster Response Force, Municipal Corporation of Delhi, Revenue Department and other agencies launched a large rescue operation using hydraulic cutters, JCB machines and other specialised equipment.

Deputy Commissioner of Police (Rohini) Shashank Jaiswal said rescuers had

established contact with one trapped person before pulling him out safely.

“We had called for oxygen beforehand. We reached out to the man and provided him with water. He was rescued safely. We are trying to establish contact with the other people trapped under the rubble and rescue them as quickly as possible,” Jaiswal said.

He also clarified reports about a vehicle buried beneath the debris, saying it belonged to a sub-inspector who had escaped moments before the collapse.

Residents rushed to the site immediately after hearing the building come down and began removing bricks, concrete slabs and twisted iron rods with their bare hands before emergency teams arrived. Videos from the scene showed firefighters carefully lifting heavy concrete slabs while trying to maintain contact with those trapped. In one video, a firefighter reassured a trapped

man, saying, “Aap chinta mat kariye, aapko bacha lenge sir.”

Authorities said every slab had to be removed carefully to prevent a secondary collapse. Police also began investigating the ownership of the building, the number of labourers present and whether construction norms had been followed.

Heavy rain also continued to disrupt daily life across Maharashtra. In Mumbai, showers accompanied by thunderstorms returned after a brief break, delaying suburban train services by 25 to 30 minutes and causing waterlogging in several parts of the city.

Nine Mumbai-bound flights were diverted to nearby airports because of poor visibility and adverse weather conditions before later returning to land safely at Mumbai airport.

Long-distance train services towards Gujarat remained disrupted because of waterlogging in the Vasai-

Virar section of neighbouring Palghar district and at several locations in south Gujarat. Rail services on the Mumbai-Pune route were yet to be fully restored after landslides in the Bhor Ghat section.

Central Railway also suspended train services between Neral and Karjat stations in Raigad district for nearly an hour after the overflowing Ulhas river submerged railway tracks. Chief Public Relations Officer Swapnil Nila said the river had been flowing above the danger level since 9.30 am following heavy rainfall in the catchment areas.

Mumbai's water supply reservoirs also continued to fill. Tulsī Lake started overflowing late Tuesday night, hours after nearby Vihar Lake overflowed, civic officials said. The India Meteorological Department forecast intermittent light to moderate rainfall over Mumbai and its suburbs.

In Nashik district, rising

water levels in the Godavari river raised concerns after continuous rainfall. The district administration advised people living along the Godavari, Kadva and Girna rivers to move valuables, livestock and other belongings to safer locations as water continued to be released from reservoirs, including Palkhed and the Nandur Madhmeshwar weir.

The rain situation also led to heated exchanges in the Maharashtra Assembly. Shiv Sena (UBT) MLA Aaditya Thackeray questioned environmental issues during discussions on the monsoon situation, asking, “Will there be a debate on mangroves and forests being cut. Will you say this was an act of God?”

Delhi also witnessed widespread waterlogging after torrential rain. The IMD issued red and orange alerts, warning of thunderstorms, lightning and heavy rainfall, with wind speeds expected to reach 40 kmph.

Areas including Sadar Bazar, Nasirpur, Greater Kailash, Badarpur, Telikawara, Mahavir Bazar, Swarup Nagar and Kushak Road were inundated, forcing pedestrians to wade through knee-high water in several places.

The Municipal Corporation of Delhi and the New Delhi Municipal Council received at least 10 complaints related to waterlogging, fallen trees and power disruptions. Traffic slowed significantly on Ring Road, Outer Ring Road and National Highway 48 near Dhaula Kuan, Mahipalpur and Rajokri because of reduced visibility and flooded stretches.

Neighbouring Gurugram also experienced severe traffic congestion as waterlogged roads left vehicles stranded. Traffic moved slowly on the service lane of the Delhi-Jaipur Highway near Narsinghpur, Basai, Umang Bhardwaj Chowk, Kadipur, Sector 10A, Sohna Road and other

major routes.

In Himachal Pradesh, flash floods disrupted connectivity in parts of Rampur subdivision of Shimla district. Rising water levels damaged a temporary bridge over the Ganvi Khad stream, cutting off access to the Kyao and Kut panchayats. Videos circulating on social media showed stranded commuters waiting on both sides of the stream while local residents worked to clear stones and restore the route.

Rajasthan also remained under the grip of an active southwest monsoon. Ramganj Mandi in Kota district recorded the state's highest rainfall of 10 cm. The IMD said a well-marked low-pressure area over northwestern Madhya Pradesh and adjoining Uttar Pradesh was likely to keep widespread rainfall active across Rajasthan for the next two to three days.

Amid the widespread weather-related disruptions, the Centre said the country's overall rainfall deficit

had narrowed to 12 per cent by July 7 after above-normal rainfall during the first week of July. During a high-level review meeting chaired by Principal Secretary to the Prime Minister P K Mishra, the IMD informed officials that although the monsoon arrived about 10 days late in Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh and Maharashtra, rainfall had improved significantly.

The PMO said weak to moderate El Nino conditions were expected during July and August but noted that an El Nino year does not necessarily result in below-normal rainfall. Officials reviewed preparedness across sectors, including agriculture, water resources, health, fertilisers, food supplies and rural development, while directing ministries and states to continue close monitoring of vulnerable districts and ensure timely response to any emerging challenges throughout the monsoon season.

From Page 1

Trump says

The attacks on shipping threatened efforts to resume fuel shipments in the strait that are crucial to the global economy.

The crossfire came during the dayslong funeral for Iran's Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, who was killed Feb. 28 in the war's first moments. The funeral, which ends Thursday, was supposed to be a period of lower tensions — though mourners have repeatedly called for the killings of Trump and Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu.

Negotiations to reach a final deal had been due to start after Khamenei's burial and focus on the toughest matters, including fully reopening the strait and rolling back Tehran's disputed nuclear programme. But the new attacks throw that into question, though neither country immediately signalled they'd walk away from the negotiating table.

“The era of bullying and extortion is over,” Iran's Parliament Speaker Mohammad Bagher Qalibaf wrote on X. “It leads nowhere. We don't fold.”

The US military's Central Command said American forces launched strikes “to impose heavy costs for targeting and attacking commercial shipping crewed by innocent civilians in an international waterway.”

It said it hit Iranian targets, including air defence systems, radars and over 60 small boats used by Iran's paramilitary Revolutionary Guard.

On Wednesday, the price of Brent crude, the international standard, spiked over 5% after Trump's comments.

The US military remains “prepared to hold Iran accountable when the agreement is not adhered to or obeyed”, it added, saying this round of attacks had ended.

Iranian state media reported explosions in several locations, including in Bandar Mahshahr, where a Guard member was killed. It also reported attacks on Bushehr, home to Iran's nuclear power plant complex.

On Wednesday morning, both Bahrain, home to the US Navy's 5th Fleet, and Kuwait, home to US Army forces, sounded missile alerts. The Guard issued a statement acknowledging targeting US military installations in both countries.

Anwar Gargash, a senior diplomat in the United Arab Emirates, called Iran's attacks on Bahrain and Kuwait “a clear indicator that Tehran remains incapable of committing to the requirements of de-escalation and turning the page on war”.

Iran and the United States agreed as part of the interim deal to allow ships to pass through the strait without paying charges for 60 days, but Tehran has insisted it must control the vessels' routes and vowed to later charge fees for passage. That would upend decades of practice in the waterway. The ships attacked Tuesday all appeared to be using a route close to Oman's shore, rather than one ordered by Tehran.

The US and many Gulf Arab states say they will not agree to Iran charging for passage through

the strait. Meanwhile, funeral ceremonies for Khamenei were held Wednesday in the Iraqi city of Najaf. Attending the services are Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian and other Iranian as well as Iraqi officials, including Prime Minister Ali Falah al-Zaidi. There will be funeral prayers later at the Imam Hussein shrine in Karbala as well.

Khamenei's son, Iran's new Supreme Leader Ayatollah Mojtaba Khamenei, has yet to make an appearance at the ceremonies, which began Saturday in Tehran. He is believed to be in hiding after reportedly being wounded in the airstrike that killed his father. Khamenei's body will then be returned to Iran to be buried Thursday at the Imam Reza shrine in Mashhad, his birthplace.

India calls for restraint

flow of global energy supplies and maritime trade.

The MEA statement came amid fresh attacks on maritime shipping in international waters — three commercial vessels, including the Saudi-flagged Wedyan and Qatari Al Rekayyat - were struck by projectiles and drones on Tuesday in the Strait of Hormuz.

The MEA said that the increasingly tense situation poses threats to the peace in the region, global energy security, and international business.

“India is deeply concerned over the recent escalation of tensions in West Asia following attacks on commercial shipping transiting international waterways. Such developments undermine regional peace, security and stability and threaten the uninterrupted flow of global energy supplies and maritime commerce,” the MEA said.

Calling for immediate de-escalation, New Delhi urged all parties to exercise maximum restraint and avoid actions that could further inflame the situation. The ministry also stressed the importance of ensuring the safety of civilians and the secure passage of commercial vessels through international sea lanes.

On Tuesday, the US Central Command (CENTCOM) launched powerful strikes hitting over 80 Iranian targets. “India is deeply disturbed by the recent incidents and tensions escalating in West Asia following the renewed threats to civilian shipping plying in international waters in the region,” the MEA said. It warned that the emerging trends pose danger to peace, security, and stability of the region, where the region faces many security concerns.

India has reaffirmed its long-held belief in the need for peaceful dialogue and has called on all concerned to show restraint and de-escalate tensions while ensuring the safety of civilians as well as uninterrupted energy supplies and international business activities. Underlining that dialogue alone is the only viable option to address the situation, it has urged all stakeholders to resume dialogue to find a peaceful solution.

Meanwhile, strategic analysts say the current crisis poses a threat since it has the possibility of leading to a much wider war in the region. Unlike other instances of conflict, this current confron-

tation can see several stakeholders being dragged into it, such as countries from the Gulf region, Israel, militant groups backed by Iran in the region, and the U.S. military forces deployed in West Asia. In this case, the bilateral war may turn into a much wider regional war with serious consequences for humanity, the economy and security.

The Strait of Hormuz forms the core of this concern. As the connection between the Persian Gulf and the Gulf of Oman and the Arabian Sea, it constitutes one of the most important maritime choke points in the world. Approximately one-fifth of the daily global supply of crude oil passes through the strait. Therefore, anything that happens there affects the international oil market immediately.

Implications for India go beyond those of a diplomatic nature, as India is one of the biggest consumers of energy in the world, relying significantly on crude oil imports from the Gulf region. In case there are disruptions of shipments via the Strait of Hormuz, it may influence the availability of energy sources as well as the cost of imports and, thus, the price of fuels within the country. The latest developments have heightened concerns over energy security, trade flows and the safety of Indian commercial interests in the region.

Further, economic implications can also be considerable. Higher costs for imported oil due to rising oil prices worldwide would adversely impact India, leading to inflationary pressure and affecting overall economic growth.

Indian govt to Nijjar killing

former High Commissioner Sanjay Kumar Verma told PTI Videos that India would take appropriate legal action if the United States shared credible evidence.

“India had sought evidence from day one, but there was a breach of trust. It is good to see India-Canada ties getting back on track after the Canadian police found no evidence linking the Government of India to the killing of Hardeep Singh Nijjar,” he said.

The developments came as law enforcement agencies from the United States, Canada and Europe carried out a coordinated crackdown, codenamed “Operation Hardball”, against transnational organised crime networks.

Authorities arrested 24 people for their alleged links to three India-based organised crime groups, including the Bishnoi gang. Investigators said the accused were involved in Nijjar's murder as well as other cross-border crimes.

Moreland said the investigation found that the Bishnoi gang had been involved in extortion, drug trafficking, kidnapping and violence in Canada and other countries.

The US Department of Justice said the operation targeted the criminal networks of Lawrence Bishnoi, Ravinder Dhandia and Jaggu Bhagwanpuria following a years-long federal investigation into Indian organised crime groups involved in targeted kill-

ings, shootings, extortion, drug trafficking and other offences across the world.

It said 37 defendants, including two alleged gang leaders who operated their criminal syndicates while imprisoned in India, had been charged under three indictments unsealed on Tuesday.

“The charges set forth in the indictment include allegations that Lawrence Bishnoi and Goldy Brar directed the 2023 assassination of a prominent Sikh leader in Canada identified by his initials HSN,” First Assistant US Attorney Bilal A Essay said.

Bishnoi has been lodged in an Indian jail since 2015, while the FBI has announced a reward of USD 50,000 for information leading to Brar's arrest.

RCMP Commissioner Mike Duheme said the joint operation disrupted organised criminal groups that “used murder, cruelty and fear to extort and control people in both Canada and the United States”.

“We won't pause for long to reflect on the work it took to get this job done; we'll keep doing what we do best to preserve public safety in Canada, in the United States, and around the world,” Duheme said.

Baruipur rape-murder

the minor girl was recovered from a pond at Surjyapur.

According to police sources, around 12.45 am on Tuesday night, an SIT team took Prabhas to Surjyapur to reconstruct the crime. During the exercise, he allegedly snatched the service pistol of Roni Sarkar, a plainclothes officer of Canning police station attached to the SIT, and fled.

Police claimed Prabhas fired a round at the pursuing officers, following which Arghya Mondal, a plainclothes officer of Baruipur Police Station and another SIT member, fired two rounds. The bullets struck Prabhas in the abdomen and below the chest. He was rushed to Baruipur Sub-Divisional Hospital, where he was declared dead.

The encounter has raised questions over how an accused in police custody managed to seize a firearm and whether the weapon's safety lock had been engaged.

As part of the mandatory inquiry into the police firing, investigators will visit the encounter site to collect evidence and reconstruct the sequence of events. The firearms used by the police personnel will be sent for forensic examination, while statements of all officers present during the operation will be recorded and cross-verified. Investigators will also ascertain the distance between the accused and the officer who fired the shots, and examine the post-mortem findings to corroborate the sequence of events.

The encounter also recalled a similar incident in 2025 when murder accused Sajjak Alam was shot by police in Uttar Dinajpur's Chopra after allegedly opening fire on officers while attempting to flee towards the Bangladesh border following his escape from police custody. Alam later died while undergoing treatment.

Prabhas's mother, Sandhya Mondal, refused to accept her son's body, saying he had “got the

result for what he did” and that she never wanted to see his face again. His wife, Champa Mondal, also distanced herself from him, saying she had endured prolonged abuse and could not claim he was innocent. The victim's father said the family had faith in the police, the administration and the Chief Minister, and was satisfied with the progress of the investigation.

The incident of encounter sparked a political debate between the ruling BJP and Opposition parties in Bengal, with the latter claiming that such encounter culture is being imported from Uttar Pradesh in Bengal and that it's an extrajudicial killing. BJP leaders have remarked that the present state government knows how to deal with goons.

Meanwhile, police have so far arrested 20 people in connection with the widespread violence that erupted after the murder. An innocent man, Indrajit Mondal, was lynched by a mob driven by rumours, while rioters torched police vehicles, vandalised public property, attacked policemen and disrupted train services before the situation was brought under control.

Jaishankar

ensuring the well-being of the Indian community.

“We jointly assessed our cooperation focusing on energy, trade, investments, defence, technology, food security and health domains. Confident that our Strategic Partnership will continue to strengthen in times to come,” the foreign minister said on X.

According to the Kuwaiti Foreign Ministry, they discussed ways to strengthen and develop cooperation in various fields.

The two sides also discussed the latest regional and international developments, it added.

The Kuwaiti foreign minister also hosted a luncheon in honour of Jaishankar and the accompanying delegation.

Jaishankar also called on Kuwaiti Prime Minister Sheikh Ahmad Abdullah Al-Ahmad Al-Sabah and thanked him for his support for the Indian community's welfare and well-being.

“Welcome his vision for stronger and mutually beneficial India-Kuwait cooperation,” the foreign minister said. Jaishankar also met Kuwaiti Defence Minister Abdullah Ali Abdullah Al-Salem Al-Sabah and the two leaders discussed cooperation in defence and maritime security.

“Glad to meet Defence Minister Kuwait Abdullah Ali Abdullah Al-Salem Al-Sabah. Spoke about defence industry cooperation and maritime security,” the foreign minister posted on X.

Separately, Jaishankar also met the Indian community in Kuwait and appreciated their role in strengthening the friendship between the two countries.

Jaishankar arrived in Kuwait on Tuesday and was received at the airport by Deputy Foreign Minister Hamad Suleiman Mashaan Al-Mashaan.

The minister is on a visit covering Qatar, Bahrain, Kuwait and Oman from July 5 to 10.

The Gulf visit comes against the backdrop of fast-evolving political dynamics in West Asia following the signing of an agreement aimed at ending the US-Iran conflict.

US launches major H-1B visa

official statement said.

“We've already started to issue dozens of subpoenas; we are going to make sure that we track down every lead. We have whistleblowers talking about some of the biggest companies like Cognizant, who have been sort of, you know, in the chatter of issues with PERM and H-1B visas,” Labour Department Inspector General Anthony D'Esposito told Fox Business on Wednesday. The action has been taken under the Task Force to Eliminate Fraud led by Vice President JD Vance.

“These abuses undermine the integrity of Department of Labour programs designed to address genuine labour shortages — not to line the pockets of bad actors at the expense of American jobs,” the statement said. This investigation reflects the OIG's unwavering commitment to dismantling human trafficking and forced-labour networks that exploit the foreign guest worker visa system, the statement added. The OIG is determined to root out every scheme that preys on vulnerable workers and takes jobs from American workers, it said. AGENCIES

Modi heads to Australia

Modi said the restoration project reflected the close historical and cultural links between the two nations. “The magnificent Prambanan Temple stands as a timeless symbol of our cultural and spiritual links. Preserving such heritage is about safeguarding the traditions that continue to inspire generations,” he wrote on X after the visit.

He said India was privileged to partner with Indonesia in the initiative and added that both countries would continue working together to celebrate their shared past while building a stronger future.

Modi described his visit to the temple as a deeply spiritual experience. Addressing the gathering at the site, he said it was an honour to inaugurate the conservation project alongside “friend, President Prabowo”. He said the cultural atmosphere in Indonesia reminded him of India and reflected the deep bond between the two countries.

“In conversations I hear, the winds here carry a scent of culture. That scent which we feel every moment on the soil of India. This scent, this cultural heritage, connects us,” Modi said.

Thanking the people of Indonesia for preserving the nearly 1,200-year-old monument, he said he prayed for stronger India-Indonesia ties, the welfare of citizens of both countries and the continued progress of the two nations. He also expressed confidence that the restoration work would attract more Indian tourists to the UNESCO-listed site.

Modi noted that Indian cultural heritage could be found in many parts of the world and said Prambanan reflected that legacy. He pointed out that the temple houses statues of Lord Shiva, Goddess Durga and Lord Gane-

sha and has remained a place of worship for centuries. The original temple layout consists of three courtyards, with the inner section featuring major temples dedicated to Shiva, Vishnu and Brahma, while the walls of the Shiva temple contain reliefs depicting the Ramayana.

The Ministry of External Affairs said the conservation project fulfilled an understanding reached during President Prabowo's state visit to India in 2025. It added that India has previously undertaken heritage restoration projects across Southeast Asia and that the Archaeological Survey of India had earlier carried out extensive documentation of the Borobudur Temple Compounds in Indonesia.

After completing his three-day visit to Indonesia, where the two countries also signed 14 agreements covering critical minerals, maritime security and other sectors, Modi departed for Australia. In a special gesture, President Prabowo personally saw him off at the airport.

On arrival in Melbourne, Modi was received by senior Australian officials and accorded a ceremonial guard of honour. “This visit will add vigour to the India Australia Comprehensive Strategic Partnership,” he said, adding that he looked forward to discussions with Prime Minister Albanese and interaction with the Indian diaspora, which he described as an important pillar of bilateral ties.

Community members welcomed him with chants of “Modi Modi” and “Vande Mataram”. Modi also watched cultural performances featuring a fusion of the Australian didgeridoo and the Indian tabla, a symphony orchestra presentation of Maa Tuihe Salaam, and a Kathak performance. He said the musical collaboration reflected the strong cultural connection between the two countries and praised the artists for preserving their traditions.

During the visit, Modi will co-chair the third annual summit with Albanese to advance cooperation in defence and security, trade and investment, education, mobility and people-to-people ties. He will travel to New Zealand for the final leg of his tour.

Higher education

1.80 crore, up 60.2 per cent.

The report said enrolment in science, technology, engineering and mathematics (STEM) courses increased from 91.5 lakh in 2014-15 to 1.02 crore in 2023-24.

Faculty strength also expanded, reaching 17.32 lakh in 2023-24. Of the total, 55.1 per cent are men and 44.9 per cent are women. Female faculty numbers increased from 5.69 lakh in 2014-15 to 7.37 lakh in 2022-23 and 7.78 lakh in 2023-24.

AISHE, the government's main source of higher education statistics, gathers information on enrolment, faculty, staff, infrastructure and examination results through a web-based data collection system. In 2022-23, 56,180 of the 60,380 registered higher education institutions participated in the survey, while participation rose to 59,533 out of 64,756 registered institutions in 2023-24.

RAI SAYS PROCEDURES WERE APPROVED BY SBI

SIT names Shukla prime accused in Ram Temple donation case

OUR CORRESPONDENT

AYODHYA: A preliminary SIT report has identified Avinash Shukla as the prime accused in the alleged theft of devotees' offerings at the Ram Temple here, linking him to a suspected 40-day racket involving nearly 70 instances of pilferage from the donation-counting system, sources said on Wednesday.

The interim findings of the three-member Special Investigation Team (SIT) were discussed during a meeting of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust on Monday, sources associated with the temple said.

According to the preliminary report, Shukla, who was engaged to count devotees' cash offerings at the temple, has been named accused No. 1 after investigators found what they described as the strongest evidence trail against him.

The report said the alleged



Police personnel escort three accused after they were brought from jail on police custody remand, in Ayodhya, Wednesday

operation revolved around Shukla, helping investigators identify five other accused and reconstruct the suspected modus operandi inside the temple's counting room.

The nine-page report, submitted to Uttar Pradesh Additional Chief Secretary (Home) Sanjay Prasad on June 23, has described the 30-year-old as the focal point of the investigation, sources said.

The SIT has, prima facie,

identified nearly 70 instances of alleged theft from the temple's counting room over a span of around 40 days, they added.

According to sources, repeated examination of CCTV camera footage allegedly showed Shukla removing and concealing bundles of donation cash and loose currency notes during counting operations on multiple occasions.

Rai rejects SIT findings
Former Trust general secre-

Gopal Rao vacates temple complex

AYODHYA: Three accused lodged in jail in connection with the alleged theft of donations at the Ram temple here were taken into police custody on Wednesday after a local court granted a 24-hour remand for further interrogation, official sources said. Investigating Officer and Circle Officer (Ayodhya) Ashutosh Tiwari took Anukalp Mishra, Lavkush Mishra and Karunesh Pandey into custody from the district jail at around 7 am on Wednesday, following which they were taken for questioning, the sources said. The police custody remand commenced in accordance with the order passed by the Special Court (Anti-Corruption) on Tuesday.

tary Champat Rai has strongly disputed the findings of the SIT, claiming that the donation counting system under scrutiny was implemented with the knowledge and approval of the State Bank of India.

In a detailed written response released after the SIT report became public, Rai rejected allegations that the trust had bypassed banking norms while handling cash

donations. He said the procedures followed at the Ram Temple were neither secret nor arbitrary and had been developed in consultation with SBI officials. Rai disclosed that the trust had entered into an agreement with SBI on February 9, 2024 for the cash counting process. According to him, every page of the agreement carried his signature as the trust's general secretary.

'Paper sold for Rs 2.25 lakh': Rahul alleges UGC-NET Sociology leak

'Govt sleeping soundly despite repeated scams'

OUR CORRESPONDENT



Rahul Gandhi said that it is futile to expect any accountability or action from Prime Minister Narendra Modi

NEW DELHI: Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Wednesday attacked the Modi government over alleged irregularities in the UGC-NET exam, saying it continues to turn a blind eye and sleep soundly despite repeated "scams" as years of hard work put in by lakhs of students hold no value for it.

The Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha said the entire country knows that it is futile to expect any accountability or action from Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan.

Gandhi shared on X a screenshot of a media report claiming that student leaders in Rohtak, Haryana, had levelled serious allegations regarding the UGC-NET June 2026 examination conducted by the NTA.

In his post in Hindi, Gandhi said, "The serious allegations that have surfaced regarding

Gandhi said no investigation would be conducted and students would not get justice

Bihar, Uttar Pradesh, Haryana, Delhi, and Rajasthan, and that the same network had claimed it could provide question papers for upcoming exams such as CSIR-NET, HTET, and ADA, Gandhi alleged.

"Even after the repeated scams in NEET and NET, the Modi government continues to turn a blind eye and sleep soundly, because the years of hard work put in by lakhs of students -- who burn the mid-night oil -- holds no value for them," the former Congress chief said.

There was no immediate response to the allegations from the NTA that conducts national-level higher education entrance exams.

Yogi defends Ram Temple Trust, says Congress, SP maligning Ayodhya

CHITRAKOOT: Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Wednesday said the SIT probing the alleged Ram temple donation theft found evidence against only eight out of the nearly 150 people engaged in counting offerings, and the entire temple Trust cannot be defamed for the wrongdoing of a "handful" of individuals.

He hit out at the Congress and the Samajwadi Party, alleging they were trying to malign Ayodhya and insult the legacy of Lord Ram over the case.

Defending the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust, Adityanath noted that the state government ordered the Special Investigation Team (SIT) probe at the recommen-



Yogi Adityanath interacts with schoolchildren at Trade Facilitation Centre (TFC), in Varanasi, on Wednesday

dation of the Trust.

Addressing a gathering after dedicating projects worth over Rs 950 crore to the public in the holy town of Chitrakoot, where Lord Ram stayed during his exile, Adityanath said the opposition parties had suddenly become active after the

case surfaced because they had found "an issue" to target Ayodhya. "You must have heard the recent reports. Congress and the Samajwadi Party suddenly became active. These are parties that have historically criticised Ayodhya, and they found an issue to exploit," he said.

"We accepted the Trust's recommendation and constituted a high-level SIT. The investigation was conducted, and the evidence showed that only six people were found stealing. "In addition, two other people were found to be part of the conspiracy, making a total of eight individuals. The SIT submitted its recommendations to the Trust, following which the Trust lodged a FIR and action was taken."

Revised NCERT texts tweak Cong position on Partition

NEW DELHI: The NCERT class 8 social science textbook which was revised following a controversy for allegedly defaming judiciary has more corrections -- a tweaked version of Congress' position on Partition in 1947 saying its acceptance as the only way forward remains a matter of debate.

While VD Savarkar's demand for Swaraj has been added in the new textbook, the references to Adolf Hitler and Nazi ideology have been dropped. Months after it stoked a controversy for allegedly defaming the judiciary, the National Council of Educational Research and Training's (NCERT) this week released the revised class 8 social science textbook -- "Exploring Society: India and Beyond" -- dropping the disputed portions.

Key Points

» While VD Savarkar's demand for Swaraj has been added in the new textbook, the references to Adolf Hitler and Nazi ideology have been dropped.

» Months after it stoked a controversy for allegedly defaming the judiciary, the National Council of Educational Research



and Training's (NCERT) this week released the revised class 8 social science textbook -- "Exploring Society: India and Beyond" -- dropping the disputed portions

The controversial portions along with references to judicial backlog and two major court verdicts have been dropped while fresh material on Public Interest Litigation (PIL), tribunals and alternative dispute resolution mechanisms has been added in the revised

textbook. However, these are not the only changes made in the revised edition.

The history chapter titled "India's Long Road to Independence" says Partition was "widely opposed even by the Indian National Congress" and that whether accepting it was

"the only way forward" remains a matter of debate.

The new edition also removes a sentence from the earlier textbook that said "the Congress leaders were helpless as communal massacres engulfed the subcontinent during Partition".

The now withdrawn textbook stated that "taking advantage of the disagreements between Hindu and Muslim leaders, the British decided to divide India and although Mahatma Gandhi and most Congress leaders opposed Partition they ended up accepting it as the only way forward".

The revised textbook also expands the story of the demand for complete independence by adding that "a similar demand for Swaraj was expressed by VD Savarkar in 1925".

TN moves SC against HC ruling on quota for Muslim converts

NEW DELHI: The Tamil Nadu government has approached the Supreme Court, challenging a Madras High Court judgment that held a person converting to Islam is not entitled to claim reservation under the Backward Class (Muslim) category solely on the basis of conversion.

The appeal has been filed by the secretary to the state government against the high court's decision, which declared unconstitutional a Government Order (GO) issued on March 9, 2024.

The impugned GO had permitted persons belonging to Backward Classes (BC), Most Backward Classes (MBC), Denotified Communities (DNC), or Scheduled Castes (SC) who subsequently converted to Islam to be treated as BC (Muslim) and obtain community certificates under one of the seven notified Muslim communities for the purpose of availing reservation benefits.

A division bench of Justices GR Swaminathan and PB Balaji struck down the GO and held that it was contrary to binding judicial precedents of both the Supreme Court and the Madras High Court.

The high court had observed that a person converting to Islam could only be treated as a Muslim and could not, by virtue of conversion alone, be classified as belonging to any specific notified Backward Class Muslim community for reservation purposes.

The judgment arose from a petition filed by Sameer Ahmed, who converted from Hinduism to Islam in 2015, with the conversion being notified through a Gazette notification in 2016.

He subsequently married according to Islamic rites and sought a certificate identifying him as belonging to the "Muslim Lebba" community to avail reservation benefits.

Kejriwal writes to 29 car makers on E20 fuel, seeks response on mileage impact

NEW DELHI: AAP national convener Arvind Kejriwal on Wednesday wrote to 29 automobile manufacturers, seeking their response on the impact of E20 fuel on vehicle mileage and performance and asked them to reply within seven days.

Kejriwal wrote separate letters to Maruti Suzuki India Limited, Toyota Kirloskar Motor and Hero MotoCorp, referring to their recent statements that the use of E20 fuel would not affect vehicle mileage. In his letters, Kejriwal sought a written assurance from these companies that if customers face any reduction in mileage or any impact on their vehicles due to the use of the E20 fuel, they would be compensated by the manufacturers.

There was no immediate reaction available from the three automobile manufacturers. In a separate communication to 26 other automobile manufacturers, Kejriwal sought their official position on whether E20 can be used in older vehicles, the extent of any impact on mileage and the possibility of mechanical damage.

He also said he would visit petrol pumps and meet automobile mechanics on Thursday to understand their views on the use of E20 fuel and discuss its impact on vehicles.

He added that he would also interact with consumers to know their experiences and

concerns. Kejriwal questioned why car manufacturers' owner manuals have prohibited the use of petrol blended with more than 10 per cent ethanol. Seeking to confirm the claim that E20 reduces mileage by only 4 to 5 per cent, he asked whether the companies would compensate consumers if mileage falls further or vehicle components are damaged. "I hope every company responds because this is an extremely serious issue for consumers across the country. I also expect all of them to reply within one week, because while their owner manuals say one thing, some companies have publicly said something entirely different," he added.

Shah reviews airport security; orders modernisation of 62 airports in 2 years

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: Union Home Minister Amit Shah and Civil Aviation Minister Ram Mohan Naidu Kinjarapu on Wednesday reviewed passenger facilities, security measures and immigration system at major airports.

They directed that airport infrastructure must be upgraded and modernised while ensuring the highest standards of security.

The Union Home Minister and Civil Aviation Minister were accompanied by the Home Secretary, Intelligence Bureau chief, Civil Aviation Secretary, CISF DG, AAI Chairman and senior officials

of the Home Ministry and Civil Aviation Ministry during the meeting. Union Home Minister Amit Shah directed that Automated X-ray Tray Return System (ATRS) must be installed at airports on a priority basis to ease the functioning and reduce manpower. He also asked the Civil Aviation Ministry to make Automated X-ray Tray Return (ATR) a mandatory requirement while constructing new airports.

Home Minister further directed that a uniform framework for seamless passenger movement encompassing entry gates, check-in, security screening, and immigration counters should be evolved to de-congest these counters.

He further directed that 62 airports, including 21 being commissioned and 41 existing, have been identified based on traffic and security inputs from the Bureau of Civil Aviation Security (BCAS) for modernisation and upgrading works.

He asked for expedited completion of the identified projects for strengthening and upgradation of the infrastructure of 21 airports which are currently under construction and 41 other airports, including those with heavy passenger traffic. Amit Shah also sought a uniform policy on the number of aerobridges to be constructed at different airports based on their passenger and aircraft traffic.

Cambodia's Angkor Wat to Myanmar's historic pagodas: How India helped revive world's heritage

India will assist Indonesia in the conservation and restoration of the Prambanan Temple

NEW DELHI: From conserving key sections of the Angkor heritage complex in Cambodia to providing grant assistance for restoration of one of Sri Lanka's five ancient temples dedicated to Lord Shiva, India has extended help to multiple partners in the past 12 years in reviving the "shared civilisational heritage", according to officials.

Adding another chapter in this cultural diplomacy of New Delhi, India will now assist Indonesia in the conservation and restoration of the Prambanan Temple complex in Yogyakarta, as Prime Minister Narendra Modi, along with President Prabowo Subianto, on Wednesday visited the UNESCO World Heritage site and unveiled a plaque, marking the inauguration of the project.

A day earlier, India and Indonesia exchanged a Letter of Intent on the joint conservation project, in which the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) will be the lead agency for the project under the Indian side.



PM Narendra Modi with Indonesian President Prabowo Subianto during the inauguration of the Prambanan Temple Restoration Project

Prior to this, the Indian government, led by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, has since 2014 offered financial assistance and expertise in material conservation to several countries in a bid to "revive shared civilisational heritage", the officials said.

In July 2015, following the reactivation of a project under the government of India, India

had signed a MoU to "provide LKR 326 million in grant assistance for the restoration of the historic Thiruketheeswaram Temple, one of Sri Lanka's five ancient Pancha Ishwarams dedicated to Lord Shiva", they said. In 2014, an MoU was signed for the restoration of UNESCO-listed My Son Sanctuary in Vietnam, one of Southeast Asia's most signifi-

Closer Look

» The Indian government, led by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, has since 2014 offered financial assistance and expertise in material conservation to several countries in a bid to "revive shared civilisational heritage", the officials said.

» In July 2015, following

the reactivation of a project under the government of India, India had signed an MoU to "provide LKR 326 million in grant assistance for the restoration of the historic Thiruketheeswaram Temple, one of Sri Lanka's five ancient Pancha Ishwarams dedicated to Lord Shiva", they said.

cant Shaivite temple complexes and the religious centre of the ancient Champa Kingdom.

Besides, from 2022 onwards, India has helped in the restoration and conservation of "key sections of the Angkor heritage complex, including Ta Prohm, Angkor Wat and Preah Vihear, reaffirming India's commitment to preserving the architectural legacy of one of the greatest centres of Hindu civilisation outside India", they said.

Also, expanding its footprint in cultural cooperation, in 2017, India signed an MoU to restore earthquake-damaged monuments in the UNESCO-listed Bagan Archaeological Zone and undertook restoration of 12 historic pagodas through the ASI.

"India also completed restoration of the historic Ananda Temple," an official said.

The same year, another MoU was signed for a restoration project in Nepal.

Nation Briefs

PM SET TO FLAG OFF NATION'S 1ST HYDROGEN TRAIN FROM JIND ON JULY 17

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi is likely to flag off the country's first hydrogen train from the Jind railway station in Haryana on July 17, sources in the railway ministry said. "As of now, we have received confirmation from the PMO that Prime Minister Modi will flag off the hydrogen train from Jind on July 17," a senior railway official said. With two driving power cars and eight passenger coaches, the train has undergone extensive trials at speeds ranging from 75 kmph to 120 kmph over the past two-and-a-half months between Sonipat, Jind and New Delhi.

'NC TO HOLD JANTAR MANTAR PROTEST ON JULY 20 OVER STATEHOOD PROMISE'

JAMMU: Deputy Chief Minister Surinder Choudhary on Wednesday said the restoration of statehood to Jammu and Kashmir would help the government work independently and effectively, and asked why the Centre has not honoured the statehood promise when it has fulfilled several others. Choudhary reiterated that the ruling National Conference would stage a protest at Jantar Mantar in New Delhi on July 20 to press the Centre to fulfil its promise of restoring statehood to Jammu and Kashmir. He said the party would urge Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Home Minister Amit Shah to honour the assurance given to the people of Jammu and Kashmir before the 2024 assembly elections.

mp

EDITORIAL

WATERS OF DISCORD

The Indus Waters Treaty has long been celebrated as one of the world's most durable international water-sharing agreements. Signed in 1960 after years of painstaking negotiations facilitated by the World Bank, it survived wars, military confrontations and prolonged diplomatic freezes between India and Pakistan. That resilience earned it the reputation of being an example of how practical cooperation could endure even when politics failed. Yet, durability alone does not make a treaty immutable. International agreements derive their legitimacy not merely from longevity, but from the continued willingness of both parties to honour both their letter and their spirit. When either of those foundations begins to erode, the legal and political assumptions underlying the treaty inevitably come under scrutiny.

The Indus basin is not an ordinary river system. Stretching across nearly 450,000 square miles, it supports millions of people and underpins the agricultural, ecological and economic life of both India and Pakistan. The treaty sought to avoid perpetual conflict by allocating the three eastern rivers—the Ravi, Beas and Sutlej—to India while assigning the western rivers—the Indus, Jhelum and Chenab—to Pakistan, subject to carefully negotiated exceptions. More importantly, the agreement established an elaborate institutional framework for resolving disagreements. The Permanent Indus Commission was designed as the first forum for discussion. Only if a technical “difference” remained unresolved could a Neutral Expert be approached. Arbitration was deliberately conceived as the final and exceptional stage, to be invoked only after earlier mechanisms had been exhausted. This layered structure reflected a conscious belief that bilateral engagement, not international litigation, should remain the principal means of preserving the treaty.

Much of the contemporary debate revolves around whether this carefully crafted dispute-resolution architecture has itself been respected. India's position has increasingly been that Pakistan has attempted to internationalise disagreements by simultaneously pursuing a Neutral Expert and a Court of Arbitration over projects such as the Kishanganga and Ratle hydroelectric schemes, thereby bypassing the sequential process envisaged under Article IX of the treaty. India has consistently argued that the treaty distinguishes clearly between a “question”, a “difference” and a “dispute”, and that arbitration is not available merely because one party chooses to invoke it. This interpretation is not without legal substance. The text of the treaty was intentionally drafted to prevent premature third-party intervention and to encourage negotiated settlement. If either party can unilaterally elevate every technical disagreement into an international legal dispute, the treaty's carefully balanced institutional design risks becoming ineffective. That concern deserves serious legal examination rather than dismissal as political rhetoric.

At the same time, the argument for holding the treaty in abeyance extends beyond procedural interpretation. It increasingly rests on a broader proposition of international law: that a treaty cannot be divorced from the wider conduct of its parties. The preamble to the Indus Waters Treaty repeatedly invokes cooperation, goodwill and friendship as the guiding principles of the agreement. Critics of Pakistan argue that decades of cross-border terrorism fundamentally contradict those foundational assumptions. From this perspective, continued sponsorship or tolerance of terrorism creates conditions fundamentally inconsistent with the cooperative relationship envisaged by the treaty. The concept of a “material breach”, reflected in Article 60 of the Vienna Convention on the Law of Treaties and widely regarded as reflective of customary international law, recognises that violation of provisions essential to a treaty's object and purpose may justify suspension of obligations. Neither India nor Pakistan is formally a party to the Convention, and the Indus treaty predates it, but customary international law often influences treaty interpretation. Whether Pakistan's conduct legally satisfies the threshold of a material breach remains open to debate among international lawyers. Yet it is no longer an argument that can be dismissed out of hand.

Nevertheless, any decision to suspend or indefinitely hold the treaty in abeyance should be approached with considerable caution. Water agreements differ fundamentally from commercial or political treaties because they govern shared natural resources on which millions of civilians depend. Actions affecting river flows inevitably carry humanitarian, environmental and diplomatic consequences extending well beyond bilateral relations. India's own long-term interests are also served by preserving its reputation as a responsible power that respects international commitments while firmly defending its national security. The more sustainable approach may therefore lie in recalibrating the treaty rather than abandoning it outright—insisting on faithful adherence to its dispute-resolution framework, fully utilising India's rights under the agreement, modernising provisions that no longer reflect present-day hydrological realities, and making clear that sustained violations of the broader conditions of peaceful coexistence cannot remain entirely divorced from water cooperation. The Indus Waters Treaty has demonstrated extraordinary resilience for over six decades. Whether it continues to survive will ultimately depend not on legal technicalities alone, but on whether both nations remain willing to uphold the mutual trust and good faith that gave the agreement meaning in the first place.

NEXUS OF GOOD



ANIL SWARUP

THE WRITER IS AN AUTHOR AND A FORMER CIVIL SERVANT

Project Ka-Lawe transformed education in Meghalaya's East Jaintia Hills, raising Grade X pass rates from below 30 per cent to over 90 per cent

This Nexus of Good Awardee, iDream Education, has managed to bring about a transformation in learning outcomes in a remote part of the country. What it has accomplished in East Jaintia Hills, Meghalaya, is truly remarkable. The model it has put in place is replicable and scalable through public-private partnership, in the true spirit of Nexus of Good.

For generations, the story of East Jaintia Hills in Meghalaya was written underground. Almost every family in this remote, hilly district either worked in a coal mine or owned one. Coal was not just an occupation—it was the organising idea of the local economy, the reason children left school early, and the reason many never saw much point in returning. When coal mining in the district was halted, the immediate, tangible income that mining offered disappeared overnight. What replaced it was not a new economy but the absence of one: families drifted into daily wage labour, a livelihood that is even more erratic and even less forgiving of a child's time in school.

The consequence showed up starkly in the district's education data. Only 25-28% of students in East Jaintia Hills were clearing their Grade X board examinations—a number low enough to represent not just an education gap, but a generational one. Two forces were compounding each other. First, with parents themselves unaware of what alternative careers existed beyond mining, school attendance became a casualty of convenience: whenever money ran short, children were pulled out and sent for daily wage work, with no one at home able to make the case for why school mattered more. Second, Meghalaya's school curriculum, textbooks, classroom teaching, and board examinations are entirely in English. But the actual language of instruction on the ground was Khasi and Pnar, the languages children speak at home and understand best. Students were, in effect, being asked to take a high-stakes examination in a language they had barely been taught to read, write, or speak with confidence.



Technology succeeded not by replacing teachers, but by enabling them to reach every child at the right level, every day

It is against this backdrop that a young Deputy Commissioner, Abhilash Baranwal, launched Project Ka-Lawe—a name that means, fittingly, “The Future.” Its premise was simple: could technology, when deployed thoughtfully, help a district rebuild the bridge between its children and their education, in a language they could not yet fully command, and in schools that could not always count on the children showing up?

In the first phase of the project, 20 schools were selected for a pilot. Each was equipped with a Smart Classroom using affordable Smart TVs and a pen drive pre-loaded with curriculum-aligned digital content, with no internet dependency—a crucial design choice in a district where connectivity is unreliable at best. The pen drive carried an offline learning platform, iPrep, loaded with English-medium digital content for Grades 6 to 10, mapped to the Meghalaya State Board curriculum: animated concept videos, practice questions, digitised syllabus books, activities, and a digital library of stories, poems, and biographies. For children who had rarely encountered English outside a textbook, this was their first sustained exposure to the language in a form that was visual, engaging, and repeatable at their own pace.

Before assuming what the intervention should look like, the district did something it deserves credit for: it measured. A baseline assessment across the pilot schools revealed that Grade X students carried learning gaps of up to four grade levels. This is a hard number to absorb, but it explained everything—students were not simply weak in English; they were being taught concepts several years ahead of what their foundational knowledge could support. The response was a

structured bridge course built into iPrep, one that told teachers precisely which junior-grade content to revisit with their students before attempting to teach grade-level material. On-field teams trained teachers in how to run this bridge course within their existing timetables, turning remediation into routine rather than an afterthought.

The early signals were encouraging. Within six months, the 20 pilot schools recorded 4,500 hours of Smart Classroom usage—evidence that the tool was being used, not merely installed. On the strength of this, the district scaled the programme to 166 classrooms, with a clear, singular focus: lifting the Grade X pass percentage.

A second layer was added as the programme matured: monthly assessments through the iPrep Assessment App, testing students on exactly what had been taught the previous month. This closed a loop that Indian classrooms often lack. It provided timely, granular feedback to teachers on which concepts had actually been understood and which had not. Teachers

used this data to continuously refine the bridge course rather than repeating a generic remedial script for every class.

The results, tracked over three years, tell their own story. Smart Classroom usage climbed from 4,500 hours to over 53,000 hours every year. And the number that had defined the district's education crisis—the Grade X pass percentage—moved from 25-28% at the outset, to 62% by the end of the second year, and to over 90% by the end of the third year.

What makes Ka-Lawe worth studying is not the technology itself, but the sequencing of decisions around it: diagnose before designing (the baseline assessment), remediate before accelerating (the bridge course), and measure continuously rather than assume (the monthly assessments). Technology here was not a substitute for teaching; it was an instrument that enabled overstretched teachers in a resource-constrained district to do something they could not have done at scale on their own. It enabled teachers to meet each child closer to where they actually were, in a language and at a pace that made sense to them.

The district administration is not resting on these numbers. With a far larger cohort of students now clearing Grade X and moving on to higher education, the focus has shifted from pass percentages to the quality of what students carry with them—improving actual marks and grade-level learning outcomes, not just the ability to clear the bar.

East Jaintia Hills' coal seams may be closed, but Ka-Lawe suggests the district has found a different kind of resource to draw on—one that, unlike coal, will not run out.

Views expressed are personal

BHARAT KI SOCH



RK PACHNANDA

THE WRITER IS A FORMER CHAIRMAN, HARYANA ELECTRICITY REGULATORY COMMISSION; DIRECTOR, BHARAT KI SOCH

India's energy future may ultimately depend as much on its oldest ideas as on its newest technologies

Long before the age of fossil fuels and centralised power grids, ancient Indian societies met their energy needs through a resilient system based on local renewable resources and ecological stewardship. By integrating community resource management with environmental ethics, ancient Indian societies followed a sustainable energy framework that supported agriculture, industry and livelihoods while maintaining harmony with nature. Early societies utilised wind energy and rudimentary water mills to capture kinetic energy for tasks like grinding grain. Meanwhile, advanced metallurgy, exemplified by achievements such as the Delhi Iron Pillar, depended on specialised charcoal-fired furnaces and sophisticated metallurgical knowledge. Foundational elements of energy, water and agriculture were revered as sacred forces: Surya (Solar Radiation) as the primary life force driving climate cycles and crop production, Vayu (Air) and Varuna (Water) as vital forces necessary to sustain civilisations.

The following Bhumī Suktam from the Atharvaveda shows this reverence:

माता भूमिः पुत्रो अहं पृथिव्याः ।
पर्जन्यः पिता स उ नःपिपतु ।

(Atharva Veda, 12.1.12)

“Earth is our mother and we are her children. The life-giving rain is our father; may he protect and nourish us.”

Further, energy security was treated as a centralised state responsibility. In Kautilya's Arthashastra, strict legal frameworks were established to govern forests.

As India transitions towards cleaner energy systems, integrating modern technologies with traditional principles of sustainability and resource stewardship can help create a secure, resilient and environmentally sustainable energy future. The Prime Minister has committed to 500 GW of clean green energy by 2030. He has been instrumental in the formation of the International Solar Alliance and the Global Biofuels Alliance with the vision of not only a clean green Bharat but also a clean green earth-on the lines of *Vasudhaiva kutumbakam*. The transition to cleaner sources of energy is no longer simply an environmental imperative; it is a developmental necessity, as the clean energy revolution presents a unique opportunity to create jobs, strengthen industries, improve quality of life and build a more equitable future. As one of the world's fastest-growing economies and a nation with ambitious developmental aspirations, India is uniquely positioned to demonstrate how clean energy can simultaneously advance economic growth, social inclusion and environmental stewardship.

Energising a Green Bharat

From Vedic environmental ethics to renewable technologies, India offers a distinctive model linking energy security, economic growth and ecological responsibility



The transition to clean energy is about creating a future in which energy is secure, affordable, reliable and sustainable for all

Recent geopolitical tensions, supply chain disruptions and fluctuations in fossil fuel prices have exposed the vulnerabilities of traditional energy systems. Countries that depend heavily on imported fuels often face economic instability when global prices spike or supply routes are disrupted. Renewable energy offers a pathway toward greater energy independence. Solar, wind, hydropower and other clean technologies enable countries to diversify their energy mix and reduce exposure to external shocks. Achieving true energy security requires comprehensive planning, robust infrastructure, modern grids, efficient storage systems and policies that ensure reliable access to energy for all citizens.

India's experience demonstrates the importance of this people-centred approach. Over the past decade, major government initiatives have sought to ensure that energy access reaches even the most remote corners of the country. The PM Sahaj Bijli Har Ghar Yojana (SAUBHAGYA) provided electricity connections to nearly 28.6 million households. The Pradhan Mantri Ujjwala Yojana (PMUY) has provided over 105 million LPG connections to women, reducing dependence on traditional biomass fuels. This shift has not only improved health outcomes by reducing indoor air pollution but has also enhanced the dignity and quality of life of countless families, particularly women.

India has emerged as a global leader in renewable energy deployment. In recent years, the country has dramatically expanded its solar and wind energy capacity, demonstrating that large-scale renewable growth is both technically feasible and economically viable. Utility-scale solar parks have attracted substantial investment and delivered electricity at increasingly competitive prices. The growth of

rooftop solar installations is particularly significant. By allowing households, businesses, schools and institutions to generate their own electricity, rooftop solar empowers consumers while reducing pressure on centralised power systems. India's non-fossil fuel energy capacity has tripled and India is the first G20 country to achieve the goals of the Paris Agreement. India's solar energy generation capacity has increased thirty-two times in the last ten years, making it the third largest solar generating nation in the world. India's achievement in ethanol blending is leading to foreign exchange savings, substantial farmer revenue and reduction in CO2 emissions.

While large-scale renewable projects are essential, distributed renewable energy (DRE) systems play a critical role in ensuring that the benefits of clean energy reach underserved areas. DRE systems include rooftop solar installations, solar-powered irrigation pumps, mini-grids, community energy projects and decentralised storage solutions. These technologies are particularly valuable in rural and remote areas where extending traditional grid infrastructure may be costly or challenging.

India's experience with solar-powered irrigation pumps demonstrates the transformative potential of decentralised clean energy solutions. Farmers can access reliable power for irrigation without relying on expensive diesel fuel. This not only reduces operating costs but also contributes to higher agricultural productivity and more sustainable farming practices. Similarly, decentralised energy systems can support schools, healthcare facilities, small businesses and community services. Reliable electricity enables better educational outcomes, improves healthcare delivery and creates opportunities for entrepreneurship. By empowering local communities,

distributed renewable energy strengthens economic resilience and promotes inclusive growth. India's transmission system has expanded tremendously and distribution reforms and adoption of advanced grid technologies are helping to strengthen a reliable and robust power system.

India is also promoting energy storage systems—both battery and pump—which are more imperative, adopting innovative financing mechanisms, blended finance structures and risk-mitigation instruments to attract investment to renewable energy projects in emerging markets. Increased investment will also support research and development, enabling us to advance emerging technologies and build domestic innovation ecosystems. Innovation remains a cornerstone of the energy transition. Advances in solar photovoltaics, battery storage, smart grids, hydrogen technologies and energy efficiency continue to improve performance while reducing costs.

International cooperation is essential; sharing best practices, research findings, technological expertise and policy experiences can accelerate progress for all nations. Collaborative research initiatives, academic exchanges and joint technology development programs can generate mutual benefits and strengthen collective capabilities.

The transition to clean energy is about creating a future in which energy is secure, affordable, reliable and sustainable for all. It is about improving lives, expanding opportunities and building stronger, more resilient economies. Indian policies prioritise inclusion, affordability and accessibility that can transform clean energy from a technological solution into a powerful engine of social and economic progress. Investments in renewable energy, grid modernisation, distributed systems, innovation and financing are all essential components of this transformation, which are being taken into account.

Clean power is not merely an environmental aspiration; it is a pathway to shared prosperity. At India's Energy Week 2025, the Prime Minister remarked: “India is driving not only its growth but also the growth of the world, with the energy sector playing a significant role.”

As the modern world confronts climate change, resource depletion and growing energy needs, our ancient insights acquire renewed relevance. The Indian civilizational approach presents a compelling framework for the future: a model of energy development rooted in renewability, community participation, ecological reverence and long-term resilience. In rediscovering this heritage, we are reminded that true progress lies not in dominating nature but in living in intelligent harmony with it.

Views expressed are personal

‘DELHI DESERVES SOLUTIONS, NOT EXCUSES’

AIMAN FATIMA

More than a year into office, Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta says her government's focus is on moving beyond announcements to implementation. From tackling air pollution through the newly launched Electric Vehicle Policy and strengthening monsoon preparedness to addressing water supply challenges, accelerating Yamuna rejuvenation, improving accountability in the health sector and expanding opportunities in higher education, the Chief Minister outlines what she describes as a governance-first approach.

In an exclusive interview, Gupta speaks about the rationale behind key policy decisions, the status of flagship projects, the future of the Mahila Samman Yojana, concerns raised by independent mechanics over the EV transition, and her long-term vision for Delhi. She also discusses the government's strategy to reduce pollution, improve civic infrastructure, modernise drainage systems and build institutions that can serve the Capital for decades.

FIVE MONTHS INTO OFFICE, WHAT DO YOU CONSIDER YOUR GOVERNMENT'S BIGGEST ACHIEVEMENT SO FAR?

If I had to describe our biggest achievement in one sentence, I would say that we have brought governance back to the centre of government. For too long, Delhi witnessed announcements over execution. Our focus has been on delivery, accountability and measurable results. Whether it is cleaning the Yamuna, introducing a comprehensive EV Policy, strengthening monsoon preparedness or improving public services, our approach has been to identify problems honestly, create a clear roadmap and ensure implementation. I believe governments should provide solutions, not excuses. While long-standing challenges cannot be solved overnight, citizens should see steady and visible progress. Success is not measured by the number of schemes announced, but by the number of lives improved. My vision is to build strong institutions and infrastructure that will serve Delhi for the next twenty-five years.

DELHI'S POLLUTION IS CAUSED NOT JUST BY VEHICLES BUT ALSO BY CONSTRUCTION DUST, INDUSTRIES AND STUBBLE BURNING. HOW MUCH IMPROVEMENT IN AQI DOES THE GOVERNMENT REALISTICALLY EXPECT?

Delhi's pollution cannot be solved by targeting a single source. Vehicular emissions account for nearly 23% of winter pollution, according to the Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM), making them a key focus of our EV Policy. We are prioritising the electrification of two-wheelers, three-wheelers and commercial goods vehicles, which contribute significantly to emissions.

At the same time, we are addressing other major pollution sources through mechanised road cleaning, stricter dust control, scientific waste management, improved public transport, greening initiatives and coordination with neighbouring states and the Central Government. Our goal is not to make unrealistic promises but to deliver measurable improvements in air quality through a comprehensive, data-driven strategy.

HOW WILL THE NEW EV POLICY ENSURE THAT SUBSIDIES REACH BENEFICIARIES QUICKLY AND TRANSPARENTLY? HOW IS THE GOVERNMENT ADDRESSING CHARGING INFRASTRUCTURE?

One of the biggest complaints people have about government schemes is that benefits often get stuck somewhere between the announcement and the citizen. We wanted to change that. Our EV Policy has therefore been designed with technology at its core. Eligible buyers will receive incentives through a Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) mechanism directly into their bank accounts after fulfilling the prescribed eligibility conditions

within 60 days. The entire process will be managed through a digital portal so that applications, verification and approvals remain transparent and trackable. This reduces paperwork, eliminates unnecessary middlemen and significantly cuts processing time.

We are also introducing digital monitoring so that every subsidy is linked to a genuine Delhi registration, ensuring that public money reaches the right beneficiary. Vehicles receiving incentives cannot simply leave Delhi immediately because safeguards have been built into the policy to prevent misuse.

Simultaneously, to address charging infrastructure concerns, we have adopted a shared responsibility model. Manufacturers, dealers, RWAs, institutions and the private sector will work alongside the government to install charging points at dealerships, housing societies and commercial spaces. The Power Department is also working actively to support the expansion of Delhi's EV charging network. Every rupee spent by the government comes from taxpayers. It should reach citizens, not files. Governance today is not about opening more counters; it is about reducing queues. Our effort is that citizens should spend more time enjoying the benefits and less time visiting government offices.

MANY INDEPENDENT MECHANICS SAY THEY CANNOT AFFORD EXPENSIVE EV DIAGNOSTIC TOOLS AND EQUIPMENT. WILL THE GOVERNMENT PROVIDE FINANCIAL ASSISTANCE OR SUBSIDIES TO SMALL WORKSHOPS?

This is a very genuine concern, and I appreciate that independent mechanics are raising it. Whenever technology changes, there is always anxiety among people whose livelihoods depend upon the existing system. My message to them is very clear: our government wants to take them along, not leave them behind. Delhi has thousands of skilled mechanics who have built their businesses over decades. They possess valuable technical knowledge, and we want that experience to become part of the EV economy.

The policy already focuses on skill development and creating an ecosystem for EV servicing. We are also engaging with industry, manufacturers and training institutions to ensure that mechanics receive affordable training and access to new technologies. As the EV ecosystem grows, we will continue to examine practical support mechanisms, including partnerships that reduce the financial burden of adopting specialised tools. The larger objective is not simply to sell electric vehicles. It is to build an entire service economy around them. The green transition must never become an unemployment transition. Technology should create opportunities for skilled workers, not uncertainty. When Delhi becomes India's EV capital, I want Delhi's mechanics to become India's most skilled EV technicians as well.

MANY AREAS CONTINUE TO FACE WATER SHORTAGES AND CONCERNS OVER WATER QUALITY. WHAT IS YOUR





60 Days

TARGET TIMELINE FOR EV SUBSIDY TRANSFER THROUGH DIRECT BENEFIT TRANSFER (DBT)



24x7

CENTRAL FLOOD CONTROL ROOM OPERATING DURING THE MONSOON



25 Years

LONG-TERM INSTITUTIONAL VISION OUTLINED BY THE CHIEF MINISTER

ROADMAP FOR ENSURING RELIABLE WATER SUPPLY?

Water is not a luxury; it is the most basic public service every government must deliver with dignity. Delhi's water challenges have built up over many years due to rapid population growth, ageing infrastructure, leakages and contamination. Our focus is on increasing water availability, reducing distribution losses and improving water quality through pipeline replacement, leak detection, modern monitoring systems, stronger treatment capacity and better local distribution networks. Our goal is clear: every household in Delhi should receive clean, reliable drinking water without having to depend on tankers or irregular supply schedules. We are committed to achieving this, step by step.

EVERY MONSOON, WATERLOGGING DISRUPTS LIFE IN DELHI. WHAT IS YOUR LONG-TERM STRATEGY TO ADDRESS THIS ISSUE?

Every monsoon, Delhiites should be talking about the rain, not worrying about whether they will reach home safely. Unfortunately, for many

years, waterlogging became an annual ritual instead of an exception. Our government is determined to break that cycle. We have approached this challenge in two ways. The first is immediate preparedness, and the second is long-term structural reform. This year, we issued the Flood Control Order 2026 well before the monsoon. Every identified waterlogging point has been assigned a nodal officer with clear responsibility and accountability. A 24x7 Central Flood Control Room is functioning, major and minor drains have undergone extensive desilting, mobile pumping units have been deployed and real-time monitoring systems are in place. For the first time, accountability has names and faces, not just files.

But let me be equally clear, desilting drains every year cannot be Delhi's permanent strategy. If every monsoon begins with emergency meetings and ends with excuses, then governance has failed. That is why we are taking forward the Drainage Master Plan with a long-term perspective. The objective is to modernise Delhi's storm-water drainage network, remove bottlenecks, improve outfall systems, integrate natural drains with engineered

infrastructure and use technology to monitor water flow before flooding occurs. Climate change has altered rainfall patterns, and our infrastructure must adapt accordingly.

We are also ensuring that urban planning, road construction and drainage planning no longer happen in isolation. Roads cannot be built without thinking about drainage, and drainage cannot be planned without considering future urban growth. Cities are not judged by how they perform on sunny days. They are judged by how they perform on the most difficult days. Our goal is to build a Delhi that remains functional even during extreme weather events.

SEVERAL KEY INFRASTRUCTURE PROJECTS, INCLUDING YAMUNA REJUVENATION AND SEWAGE WORKS, WERE PENDING WHEN YOUR GOVERNMENT TOOK OFFICE. WHERE DO THESE PROJECTS STAND TODAY?

When our government assumed office, we inherited not just pending files but pending responsibilities. Many critical infrastructure projects had remained on paper for years

“GOVERNMENTS COME AND GO, BUT GOOD GOVERNANCE SHOULD REMAIN. THAT IS THE LEGACY I WANT TO LEAVE BEHIND”

while Delhi continued to bear the consequences in the form of pollution, water shortages and inadequate sewerage infrastructure. We are no longer measuring success by projects announced but by projects completed. The Delhi Jal Board's pending works, including sewage treatment plants, trunk sewer networks and the Yamuna rejuvenation programme, have been placed under continuous review. We have established fixed timelines, strengthened inter-departmental coordination and introduced regular monitoring so that bottlenecks are identified and removed quickly. Wherever approvals were delayed, we have accelerated decision-making. Wherever execution had slowed down, accountability has been fixed.

Let us not reduce Yamuna rejuvenation to merely an environmental project. It is a civilisational responsibility. A river that has nurtured Delhi for centuries deserves much better than becoming a drain. That is why we are approaching this mission scientifically, from interception and diversion of untreated sewage to increasing sewage treatment capacity, improving drain management and restoring ecological health. At the same time, sewer infrastructure is being expanded because a clean Yamuna cannot exist without a modern sewer network. These two issues are inseparable. The Yamuna is not a political issue for us; it is a generational responsibility. People will judge us not by how many review meetings we held, but by whether they can actually see cleaner water, stronger infrastructure and visible progress on the ground. That is exactly the standard we have set for ourselves.

THE MAHILA SAMMAN YOJANA WAS ONE OF YOUR GOVERNMENT'S MAJOR PROMISES. WHEN CAN ELIGIBLE WOMEN EXPECT ITS ROLLOUT?

Women's empowerment is not a slogan for our government; it is a governance priority. A developed Delhi is simply not possible unless women feel financially secure, socially respected and economically independent. The Mahila Samman Yojana was conceived with this larger objective. The necessary administrative processes, beneficiary verification mechanisms and implementation framework are being put in place so that the scheme is transparent, targeted and sustainable. Our effort is to ensure that every eligible woman receives the benefit without unnecessary delays or leakages. I have always believed that public welfare schemes should be built on strong

systems rather than hurried announcements. Citizens expect delivery, not publicity. That is why we are taking the time to create a robust mechanism before full-scale implementation.

But our commitment to women goes much beyond one scheme. Whether it is improving public safety, expanding opportunities for education and employment, promoting women entrepreneurs or making public transport safer, every department has been asked to place women at the centre of policy making. The measure of a government's success is not how loudly it speaks about women, but how confidently women are able to move forward because of its policies. Our vision is that every daughter, every student, every working professional and every homemaker in Delhi should feel that this government stands firmly beside her aspirations.

THERE HAVE BEEN ALLEGATIONS OF IRREGULARITIES IN THE HEALTH SECTOR. HOW MANY CASES HAVE BEEN IDENTIFIED SO FAR, AND WHAT ACTION HAS BEEN TAKEN?

Healthcare is one sector where there can be absolutely no compromise. Every rupee that belongs to patients must be spent on patients. Every hospital must function with transparency, accountability and integrity. Wherever complaints or irregularities have come to our notice, they have been taken seriously. Investigations have been initiated, records have been examined and, wherever prima facie evidence has emerged, appropriate administrative and legal action has been initiated in accordance with the law. We believe that accountability strengthens institutions; it does not weaken them.

At the same time, our objective is not merely to identify irregularities after they occur. We are strengthening systems so that such irregularities become far more difficult in the future. Greater digital monitoring, transparent procurement, improved audit mechanisms and stricter administrative oversight are all part of this reform process. People often ask whether we are conducting a witch hunt. My answer is simple, there is a difference between political vendetta and administrative accountability. We are interested in the latter. The taxpayer's money is sacred. Every rupee diverted through negligence or corruption is a rupee taken away from a patient waiting for treatment. Our focus remains on building a healthcare system that inspires trust, where doctors can work with dignity, patients receive quality care and public resources are used honestly and efficiently.

DELHI CURRENTLY HAS NO PRIVATE UNIVERSITY. IS THE GOVERNMENT OPEN TO ALLOWING PRIVATE UNIVERSITIES IN THE FUTURE?

Delhi is India's capital and one of the country's biggest knowledge hubs. We have some of the finest public institutions, but as aspirations grow and the demand for quality higher education increases, we must also think about expanding opportunities. We want more seats, better quality and greater access to world-class education for Delhi's students. If reputed private institutions can contribute to that objective while maintaining high academic standards, transparency and affordability, we are certainly open to examining such proposals within the appropriate legal and regulatory framework.

We also want universities to become centres of innovation in artificial intelligence, clean energy research, biotechnology, public policy and advanced manufacturing so that students graduating from Delhi are prepared not just for today's jobs but for tomorrow's economy. The cities that will lead the 21st century will not be those with the tallest buildings, but those with the strongest universities. Our vision is to make Delhi not only the political capital of India but also one of the country's foremost centres of higher education, research and innovation. If that requires new models, new partnerships and new institutions, we will move forward with an open mind, while always keeping students' interests at the centre of every decision.

HIGH-LEVEL HOME MINISTRY MEET

India, Myanmar review security ties and situation along borders

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: India and Myanmar on Wednesday reiterated the need for enhancing bilateral security cooperation with an exchange of intelligence and better coordination to tackle cross-border crimes and threats during the 23rd National Level Meeting here on July 7-8.

The Indian delegation was led by Home Secretary Govind Mohan and the Myanmar counterpart was Major General Min Thu, Deputy Minister of Home Affairs.

The delegations exchanged views on the bilateral discussions held under the existing platforms on the evolving situation in the regions and in depth discussions also took place on enhancing cooperation to tackle terrorism, insurgency, narcotics, arms trafficking, human trafficking, wildlife, cybercrimes and other related threats.

Both the countries also agreed to ramp up coordination, intelligence and operational level cooperation for enhanced capabilities to address emerging security concerns.

India reiterated the strategic importance of Myanmar for India's Neighbourhood First, Act East and MAHASAGAR (Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions) policies and also re-affirmed India's interest in taking bilateral relations to greater heights.

The delegations also reviewed the situation along the borders and agreed on the need to maintain peace and sta-



Highlights

- » The Indian delegation was led by Home Secretary Govind Mohan and the Myanmar counterpart was Major General Min Thu, Deputy Minister of Home Affairs
- » Both the countries also agreed to ramp up

coordination, intelligence and operational level cooperation for enhanced capabilities to address emerging security concerns

» Myanmar assured India that its territory would not be utilised against India's security concerns

bility along the borders of the two countries.

Both the countries were firm in their stance that neither of their territories would be allowed to utilise it for any activity that could jeopardise the security of the other country. Myanmar assured India that its territory would not be utilised against India's security concerns.

Both the delegations also exchanged views on the need for expedited execution of ongoing connectivity proj-

ects like Kaladan Multi-Modal Transit Transport Project and India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway for regional connectivity and economic cooperation.

Both India and Myanmar concluded the meeting by expressing mutual satisfaction over the discussions and agreed to sustain close interactions through various bilateral engagement mechanisms for enhanced security and coordination to address common security concerns.

'PRAKRITIK KHETI SAMVAD'

Saini interacts with farmers, assures their suggestions to be implemented

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Wednesday, made a major announcement to promote natural farming in the state, saying that 'Prakriti Shri Anna Prerak Kisan Committees' will be constituted in every district of Haryana.

The primary responsibility of these committees will be to reach out to farmers, visit their farms and coordinate with the government to connect them with natural farming. They will, in effect, serve as ambassadors of natural farming.

The Chief Minister was addressing the 'Prakritik kheti Samvad', organised by the Haryana Agriculture and Farmers' Welfare Department in Panchkula. During the programme, he



Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini presenting a copy of the Bhagavad Gita to a Swedish delegation led by IKEA India CEO Patrik Antoni, at Chandigarh. MPOST

also personally interacted with farmers and assured them that the suggestions received from them would be implemented at the earliest. He also directed officers of the Agriculture Department to release the subsidy to farmers practising natural farming who have applied for assistance to purchase cows.

Addressing the gathering, Saini said that natural farming is not merely a method of cultivation but a campaign to

Second Drishti-10 crash in 18 months raises questions over India's MALE UAV programme

Drishti-10 MALE UAV is manufactured by Adani Defence and Aerospace

SIMONTINI BHATTACHARJEE

NEW DELHI: The Drishti-10 MALE UAV, manufactured by Adani Defence and Aerospace, crashed mid-air during a training exercise at the Porbandar air base in Gujarat on Wednesday, marking the latest setback for the indigenously developed surveillance drone.

Indian Navy officially confirmed the incident by saying that there had been an accident involving the UAV while undertaking a training operation. The official statement released by the Navy also made it clear that there had been no casualties on the ground as a result of the crash and an inquiry into the matter would be conducted.

This recent incident happened just about a year after another Drishti-10 crashed into the ocean off the coast of Porbandar in a pre-acceptance



test on January 14, 2025, before induction into service with the Indian Navy.

At that previous accident, during the testing process, communication between the UAV and the ground control station was lost, and the vehicle was intentionally ditched into the sea.

It should be noted that there were no deaths at all from that accident, and the drone was eventually recovered. As the drone had not yet been officially accepted for service with the Navy, the UAV was still in the hands of the manufacturer

CBI raids Mumbai firms in Rs 30.63 cr PNB loan fraud

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) conducted raids at various places in connection with an alleged Rs 30.63-crore Punjab National Bank (PNB) loan fraud involving Mumbai-based firm Maxx Mobile Communication Ltd and its directors on Wednesday.

The CBI had registered the case on July 7 after PNB's SAM Branch, Mumbai filed a complaint against Maxx Mobile Communication Ltd, its directors, unknown public servants and private individuals for allegedly causing the bank an unauthorised loss of Rs 30.63 crore.

According to the CBI, the accused in the case had allegedly conspired to avail higher cash credit limits from PNB and other consortium member banks by misrepresenting and falsifying debtor figures among other things.

The agency alleged that Maxx Mobile Communication had obtained term loans from the bank and had diverted/siphoned the amount for purposes other than for which the loan was sanctioned.

The CBI said that during searches conducted on July 8, records of various banks, property documents and other incriminating documents were recovered.

RTI flags Congress occupied former 24 Akbar Road headquarters without authorisation since 2013

NEW DELHI: An official Right to Information (RTI) reply has stated that the Congress has remained in 'unauthorised occupation' of its former headquarters at 24, Akbar Road in New Delhi since June 26, 2013.

The RTI response also says that the Union government has not received any rent for the property during this period and that the party's outstanding dues are still being assessed.

The RTI reply, furnished by the Directorate of Estates, which falls under the Union Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs, states that Bungalow No. 24, Akbar Road, located in Lutyens' Delhi, was allotted to the Congress party on August 7, 1992.

However, its allotment was cancelled with effect from

Closer Look

- » The RTI response also says that the Union govt has not received any rent for the property during this period
- » The RTI applicant also sought copies of notices, if any, issued by the government asking the Congress to vacate the bungalow
- » Meanwhile, the recent RTI also sought information regarding 11, Ashoka Road, another address in Lutyens' Delhi and the former headquarters of the BJP
- » The Directorate declined to provide the information, stating that such records are not maintained in a compiled form

June 26, 2013, and the bungalow has remained under the party's unauthorised occupation ever since, according to the government.

The RTI applicant also sought copies of notices, if any, issued by the government asking the Congress to vacate the bungalow.

after submitting the SIR form will be able to exercise their franchise and avail the benefits of government schemes. Assuring full support to the people, the Chief Minister said anyone facing difficulty in filling the SIR form should seek assistance from local Aam Aadmi Party volunteers.

In a message to the people, CM Mann said, "It is very important for every eligible voter to fill out the SIR form so that your name is included in the new electoral roll. If your name does not appear in the voter list, you will not be able to exercise your democratic right to vote. I urge every Pun-

jabi to complete this process on time and protect this invaluable right."

The Chief Minister said that the Special Intensive Revision is aimed at strengthening democracy at the grassroots level and appealed to people across the state to participate enthusiastically.

He assured full support and cooperation to every citizen during the process.

Mann stated, "If anyone faces any difficulty while filling out the SIR form, they should contact the local volunteers of the Aam Aadmi Party, who will extend every possible assistance."

Punjab ties up with NLDL to digitise logistics, boost industrial competitiveness

MPOST BUREAU

Chandigarh - In a significant step to slash logistics costs and sharpen the state's industrial competitiveness, the Punjab government signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with NICDC Logistics Data Services Limited (NLDL) to integrate the state's supply chain with the Unified Logistics Interface Platform (ULIP).

Punjab Industries and Commerce minister, Aman Arora witnessed the signing of the MoU by Jaspreet Singh, Director of Industries & Commerce and Takayuki Kano, Chief Executive of NLDL, here at Udyog Bhawan. Administrative Secretary of Industries and Commerce Gurkirat Kirpal Singh was also present on the occasion.

Arora said that the agreement would enable real-time data sharing across multiple government systems and private logistics operators through a single interface. An efficient logistics ecosystem is a critical enabler for industrial growth. This partnership will simplify business processes, improve freight movement by real-time visibility and directly benefit the exporters, MSMEs and transporters, he added.

Calling it a key step toward making Punjab a preferred investment destination, the Industries Minister said that the platform would help lower transaction costs and strengthen the state's ease-of-doing-business credentials. The ULIP integration is expected to enhance coordination among government departments, logistics service providers and industry stakeholders, besides, improving supply chain visibility, reduce inefficiencies, and boost Punjab's export competitiveness.

Arora stated that Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann led Punjab government has been pursuing progressive reforms to build a modern, transparent and investor-friendly industrial ecosystem.

Jharkhand CM inaugurates two-day National Stakeholders Consultation

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Jharkhand Chief Minister Hemant Soren on Wednesday inaugurated a two-day National Stakeholders Consultation organised by the state government to deliberate on Jharkhand's Vision 2050, with a focus on information technology, artificial intelligence, digital governance and emerging technologies.

Soren said Jharkhand should be known "not only for its mines but also for its minds." He said the state's identity must extend beyond resources to research, beyond extraction to innovation and beyond growth to inclusive and sustainable development.

The Chief Minister said equal importance must be given to research, innovation and a knowledge-based economy alongside the state's natural resources.

The convergence of Jharkhand's traditional knowledge with modern technology, he said, would drive the development of both the state and the nation.

The consultation saw par-

ticipation from representatives of leading organisations, including Microsoft, Google and IBM, who shared recommendations on strengthening the state's digital ecosystem, attracting technology investments and preparing Jharkhand for future industries.

During the session, the state government presented concept papers on the proposed Jharkhand AI Policy, Investment Promotion Policy, Tourism Policy, Textile Policy, JIADA Regulations and PPP Policy, inviting feedback from industry stakeholders to make them more investor-friendly and future-ready.

A Business-to-Government interaction was also held to explore investment opportunities and partnerships in the identified sectors.

Soren reiterated the government's commitment to developing policies that encourage investment, generate employment and accelerate inclusive growth, adding that stakeholder consultations would play a key role in shaping the state's long-term development roadmap.

Report: 7 in 10 children missed school due to extreme heat

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Nearly seven in every 10 school-going children across the country missed school or routine activities because of extreme heat from May to June this year, according to a new report.

The report, based on an assessment conducted by child rights NGO CRY, titled "Feeling the Heat: Children's Voices on Heat, Well-Being and Learning in India", gathered responses from 3,096 school-going children aged 10-17 years across 27 states and Union Territories. "About 88 per cent of children felt this year's summer was hotter than previous years. Nearly 68 per cent reported missing school or routine activities due to heat-related distress, while 76 per cent said the heat negatively affected their ability to focus on studies."

"Around 47 per cent identified the afternoon as the most difficult part of the day, and more than 45 per cent said school hours were particularly uncomfortable, underscoring



the challenges children face while learning in increasingly hotter conditions," the report said.

India witnessed repeated heatwave conditions during the summer of 2026, with temperatures crossing 45 degrees Celsius in several states. Schools in many regions revised their timings, curtailed outdoor activities and, in some places, temporarily suspended classes.

According to the Annual Climate Statement 2025 of the India Meteorological Department (IMD), 2024 was India's warmest year on record since 1901, while the decade 2016-2025 was the warmest ever recorded, with 10 of the 15 warmest years occurring during this period.

The assessment also flagged the growing health burden of

extreme heat. Nearly 63 per cent of children reported experiencing dehydration, 51 per cent suffered headaches, and 44 per cent experienced extreme fatigue during periods of intense heat.

Heat-related challenges extended beyond schools into children's homes.

More than half (53 per cent) of the respondents reported frequent power interruptions or overheated living spaces, while nearly three in 10 experienced water shortages, further compounding their discomfort and affecting their daily routines.

The findings also revealed that the impact of extreme heat is not experienced equally. Around 71 per cent of children from families depending on daily-wage or manual labour reported severe heat-related distress, compared to 46 per cent of children from other households, highlighting how climate-related risks disproportionately affect children from economically vulnerable communities.

ED searches premises linked to Reliance Anil Ambani Group

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: Directorate of Enforcement (ED) has conducted fresh searches at the premises of E-Complex Private Limited and the residence of one of its directors linked to the Reliance Anil Ambani Group (RAAG) in its ongoing money laundering probe against the alleged siphoning of public money from Reliance Home Finance Limited and Reliance Commercial Finance Limited.

The searches were conducted on July 7 under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), 2002, during which the ED recovered several incriminating documents, along with certain records pertaining to immovable property and other evidence of transactions and assets of benefit or belonging to RAAG.

THE BODY WAS PLACED IN A CASKET DRAPED IN IRAN'S FLAG

Funeral processions held in holy Iraqi cities for Khamenei

NAJAF: Thousands of mourners attended funeral processions for Iran's Ayatollah Ali Khamenei on Wednesday in the holy Iraqi cities of Najaf and Karbala as part of day-long funeral ceremonies for the Islamic Republic's late supreme leader.

The ceremonies began on Saturday, with authorities shutting down streets, airspace and daily life in Tehran, Iran's capital, as throngs commemorated the life of the man who led Iran for decades with an iron fist while confronting the West. His body was later taken from Najaf to Karbala before it is to be returned to Iran.

Khamenei was killed in late February in wide-scale US and Israeli strikes on Iran that started the war. The 86-year-old supreme leader was among several senior Iranian leaders killed in strikes during the war.

Talks on ending the war between the United States and Iran appear to be on hold until after the burial.

However, strikes from both sides in the Persian



The coffin of the late Iranian Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei being carried by mourners to the Imam Ali Shrine in Najaf on Wednesday

Gulf on Tuesday and into Wednesday raised risks that the interim agreement to end the monthslong conflict that engulfed the Middle East could completely break down.

The US military attacked Iran early Wednesday after it said Tehran struck three ships in the Strait of Hormuz. Iran then launched retaliatory strikes on Kuwait and Bahrain.

Khamenei's body arrived on Tuesday in Najaf, considered one of the holiest of cities for millions of Shiite Muslims worldwide. Mourners holding portraits of Khamenei wel-

Highlights

- » Khamenei was killed in late February in wide-scale US and Israeli strikes on Iran
- » Talks between the United States and Iran appear to be on hold until after the burial
- » The US military attacked Iran early Wednesday after it said Tehran struck three ships in the Strait of Hormuz

comed the body and senior officials escorting it, including Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian and Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi.

The body was placed in a casket draped in the Islamic Republic's flag and encased in glass. Some supporters performed self-flagellation on the streets, while others waved Iranian as well as red and black flags symbolising mourning and revenge.

AGENCIES

US will give Patriot missile license to Ukraine: Trump at NATO meet

ANKARA: President Donald Trump said Wednesday that the US will give a license to Ukraine to manufacture Patriot air defence systems to help counter Russian missile attacks, a huge coup for Ukraine which has badly needed the technology for the war now in its fifth year.

"We'll give them the right to make Patriots. We'll show them how to do it," Trump said as he met with Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy at a NATO summit in Türkiye. "I think they can produce them pretty quickly."

Patriots are expensive, in high demand and take a long time to produce. Zelenskyy has for years been asking for more of them, and more recently for a license so that Ukraine can manufacture its own.

The tone of Trump's meeting with the Ukrainian leader was a break from earlier encounters which ended in acrimony, and Trump praised Zelenskyy's willingness to reach a deal on ending the fighting in Ukraine.

He said the Ukrainian president has "done an amazing job" and "been very effective" in the war. "We've actually developed a good relationship. It's hard to believe," Trump said, adding he believed a deal on ending the war was on the horizon and that the US would



US President Donald Trump (R) with Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy

“ZELENSKY HAS FOR YEARS BEEN ASKING FOR MORE OF THEM, AND MORE RECENTLY FOR A LICENSE”

"work on some kind of security package" to provide to Ukraine.

Trump wasn't as friendly, however, with some his NATO partners, saying he was unhappy with the alliance for pushing back against his efforts to take control of Greenland and for not supporting his war in Iran. NATO's Euro-

pean members plus Canada have scrambled to meet the increased defence spending targets Trump has demanded, as the US draws down the number of troops it has in Europe and insists that the continent take more responsibility for its own security. But Trump reopened old wounds as he arrived at the meeting of 32 NATO leaders by insisting again that the United States should control Greenland, a semi-autonomous Danish territory. He blasted some European countries for refusing to participate in the Iran campaign, singling out Spain as "a terrible partner in NATO" and renewing his threats to cut off trade.

AGENCIES

Russian attacks kill 4 across Ukraine, striking Kyiv for 2nd straight day



Rescue workers search for victims after a Russian air attack in Kharkiv, on Wednesday

KYIV: Russian drones and missiles killed four people across Ukraine on Wednesday in attacks before dawn and at midday, as Moscow kept up its pressure on the capital of Kyiv in the latest phase of the over 4-year-old war.

Ukraine struck oil refineries in Russia's Saratov and Tatarstan regions, according to President Volodymyr Zelenskyy, who met with US President Donald Trump on the sidelines of the NATO summit in Türkiye. Trump said the US would give a license to Ukraine so it could manufacture Patriot air defence systems to counter Russia. In Kyiv, several explosions were heard shortly after midnight, even before authorities could issue an alert to give civilians time to find shelter.

The early morning Russian attacks killed one woman and injured two others in Kyiv

The early morning Russian attacks killed one woman and injured two others in Kyiv, according to city administration head Tymur Tkachenko. The State Emergency Service said the attack damaged several administrative buildings and warehouses, as well as a garage complex and several trams.

Hours later, another Russian drone struck Kyiv's Desnianskyi district, killing a second person and injuring six others, Tkachenko said.

AGENCIES

PRESIDENT XI TELLS SCIENTISTS

‘Make China leading power in sci-tech by ’35’

BEIJING: President Xi Jinping on Wednesday asked Chinese scientists and engineers to make the country a leading power in science and technology by 2035 to achieve high-level self-reliance.

Xi said that accelerated efforts should be made to achieve high-level self-reliance and strength in science and technology, and leverage sci-tech innovation to accelerate Chinese modernisation.

"We must seize the historic opportunity, rise to the challenges of the times, accelerate efforts to achieve high-level self-reliance and strength in science and technology, and make steady progress toward the 2035 goal of becoming a leading coun-



try in science and technology," Xi said while addressing a meeting here that brought together heads of the top scientific and engineering bodies of the country.

He said the 15th Five-Year

Plan period (2026-2030) is a critical phase for tackling tough challenges in building up the country's strength in science and technology, state-run Xinhua news agency reported. At the meeting, Xi presented Chi-

na's top sci-tech award for the year 2025 to Chen Liquan, a researcher at the Institute of Physics under the Chinese Academy of Sciences, and Ben De, a researcher at the China Electronics Technology Group Corporation and also a member of the Chinese Academy of Engineering. Chen is the founder of China's lithium battery sector. Ben De is an expert in radar technology.

In recent years, China has made big strides in several frontier technologies, artificial intelligence (AI), electric vehicles (EVs), and battery technology, aided by massive state support, a huge domestic market, strong manufacturing capabilities, and a large pool of engineers.

AGENCIES

Pak: 54 terrorists, 38 security personnel killed in Balochistan

ISLAMABAD/KARACHI: At least 54 terrorists, 38 security personnel and four civilians were killed during the last four days in various incidents in the restive Balochistan province, the ISPR said Wednesday.

The trouble began on the night of July 4 and 5 when Fitna al-Khawarij terrorists attacked the innocent local population in Hanna Urak, Director General Lt Gen Ahmed Sharif Chaudhry of the Inter-Services Public Relations (ISPR), military's media wing, told a press conference at Rawalpindi.

The state uses the term Fitna al-Khawarij to refer to the banned Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP) and its affili-

ates. Four civilians were killed and six injured during that incident, he said.

In the second incident, terrorists late Monday night carried out a multi-directional attack on a police check post, set up to guard a Pumping Station in Mangi Dam in Ziarat district, in which nine policemen, including two station house officers (SHOs), were killed.

Several police officials were taken as hostages, making the subsequent operation by paramilitary Frontier Corps, army personnel and other law enforcement agencies (LEAs) complicated, he said, adding, however, 18 policemen were killed by the terrorists.

AGENCIES

Pak rescue teams locate wreckage of missing plane in Arabian Sea

KARACHI: Pakistani search and rescue teams on Wednesday located the wreckage of a private cargo plane that went missing while flying from Sharjah in the UAE to Karachi with five crew members on board a day earlier, officials said.

The wreckage of the Boeing 737 cargo aircraft, operated by Karachi-based private airline K2 Airways, was recovered from 53 nautical miles south of Ormara on the Balochistan coast, the Pakistan Airports Authority (PAA) said in a post on X.

The Pakistan Navy and the Pakistan Maritime Security Agency (PMSA) "successfully located and identified wreckage" of the plane after about 12 hours of search and rescue operations in the deep Arabian Sea, it said.

AGENCIES

Several health workers in Congo's Ebola outbreak go on strike over pay issues as deaths near 600

Workers alleged they were working with limited gear, and were being treated unfairly

BUNIA: The healthcare workers at the epicentre of Congo's Ebola outbreak are walking off their jobs to protest delays in their payments, threatening efforts to slow the outbreak that officials said continues to spread faster than the response.

In Ituri province, the hardest hit among the three provinces in eastern Congo affected by the outbreak, some of the health professionals and other front-line workers told The Associated Press they've not been paid their wages and bonuses since the outbreak was declared on May 15.

They also alleged they were working with limited gear, and were being treated unfairly by authorities as well as response teams.

"Since the Ebola virus disease outbreak was declared, we've been demanding payment for our work," Dr Biensi Kano, a member of the epidemiological surveillance committee in Ituri's capital, Bunia, told The Associated Press.

The latest government data shows 1,708 recorded cases, including 580 deaths, and that



Treatment centres at near-full capacity

the first month of this Ebola outbreak was already the worst on record, health authorities said.

The strike comes at the start of enrollment for clinical trials for the treatment of the Bundibugyo virus that is responsible for this outbreak.

The World Health Organisation representative in Congo, Dr Anne Ancia, said Tuesday that the virus continues to spread, fuelled by population movements and insecurity, while some treatment centres

are at near-full capacity.

The non-payment of benefits "exposes us and our families to significant socio-economic difficulties and seriously undermines our living conditions," said Kano.

In an official notice to national and provincial authorities over the weekend, front-line workers in Ituri threatened to strike if the wages were not paid in 24 hours. By Tuesday, some had already stopped working although no official strike has been declared.

Key Points

- » Drone strikes on the city have destroyed civilian infrastructure
- » More than 30 million people are in need of humanitarian assistance

DRONE WAS HIT THE OUTSKIRTS OF KHARTOUM

civilians.

A separate drone strike on Tuesday hit a transport vehicle near a water facility in the province, killing two people, according to Emergency Lawyers, which tracks violence in

Sudan.

The previous day, 13 civilians, including five women, were killed when a drone hit their vehicle as they headed to a wedding in a al-Shaatout town, in North Kordofan province,

Emergency Lawyers said.

"This attack is part of an escalating pattern of drone attacks on civilians as drones continue to fly over the northern parts of the province... monitoring residents' movements," the group said in a statement.

North Kordofan has seen a surge in drone strikes amid repeated international concerns about the RSF closing in on the strategic city of el-Obeid, which is home to the army's 5th Infantry Division.

Drone strikes on the city

have destroyed civilian infrastructure, including power facilities and neighbourhoods, and targeted bridges and key supply routes, according to the UN.

The war in Sudan, which started in April 2023 after long-simmering tensions between the army and the RSF, has killed at least 59,000 people, displaced some 13 million and pushed many parts of the country into famine.

More than 30 million people are in need of humanitarian assistance.

AGENCIES

World Briefs

PAK ARMY CHIEF VOWS TO CRUSH CROSS-BORDER MILITANCY

ISLAMABAD: Pakistan Army chief Field Marshal Asim Munir vowed on Wednesday to crush cross-border militancy with full force. Addressing the graduating officers at the National Defence University, Munir said that the armed forces remain fully cognizant of attempts by hostile intelligence agencies to destabilise Pakistan. "Terrorism emanating from across the borders will be crushed with the full might of the state," he said. He said the armed forces, with the support of the nation, will ensure that terrorist sanctuaries of these proxies, along with their facilitators, are completely dismantled.

LAST WOMAN HANGED IN UK RECEIVES CONDITIONAL PARDON AFTER 70 YEARS

LONDON: The last woman to be hanged in the UK on the charge of murdering her boyfriend was on Wednesday granted a conditional pardon after more than 70 years by King Charles III, on the advice of the British government. Ruth Ellis shot David Blakely and was convicted of murder after a trial and executed on July 13, 1955. The application for a pardon was brought by four of Ellis' grandchildren on the basis that her culpability was "profoundly" shaped by domestic abuse, trauma and circumstances that were never properly recognised at her trial. The UK has since abolished the death penalty in law. The ministerial decision was made on the basis that imposition of the death penalty would not have been sustained under modern law.

— RISING US-IRAN TENSIONS, SPIKE IN OIL PRICES DENT SENTIMENT —
Stock markets slump more than 2%

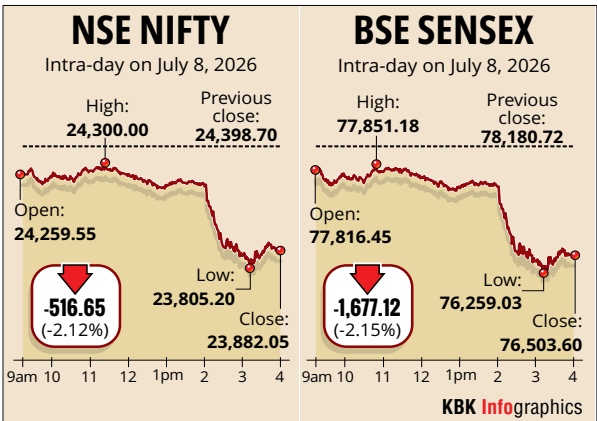
MPOST BUREAU

MUMBAI: Equity benchmark indices Sensex and Nifty tumbled over 2 per cent on Wednesday after US President Donald Trump said the interim agreement with Iran is over, leading to a sharp rally in crude oil prices. Besides, investors shifted to a risk-off mode following pre-earnings anxiety over sluggish first-quarter forecasts amid a negative trend in global markets, traders said.

The 30-share BSE Sensex tanked 1,677.12 points, or 2.15 per cent, to settle at 76,503.60. During the day, it plummeted 1,921.69 points, or 2.45 per cent, to 76,259.03.

A total of 3,211 stocks declined, while 1,070 advanced and 173 remained unchanged on the BSE. On similar lines, the 50-share NSE Nifty tumbled 516.65 points, or 2.12 per cent, to end at 23,882.05.

“Indian equity markets witnessed a sharp sell-off as US President Donald Trump declared the interim peace deal with Iran is ‘over’ follow-



ing Iranian attacks on commercial vessels in the Strait of Hormuz, reigniting geopolitical tensions and raising fresh concerns over global energy supplies,” Ponnudi R, CEO of Enrich Money, an online trading and wealth tech firm.

The renewed escalation triggered a sharp rebound in crude oil prices, which surged nearly 7 per cent, sending shockwaves across global financial markets, he added.

All firms in the Sensex pack ended in the red. InterGlobe

Aviation, Maruti, Hindustan Unilever, Bajaj Finance, Kotak Mahindra Bank and Mahindra & Mahindra were major laggards.

The BSE MidCap Select index tanked 2.14 per cent, and the SmallCap Select index dropped 1.61 per cent.

All sectors ended lower. Services fell sharply by 3.21 per cent, PSU Bank (2.76 per cent), MidSmall Private Banks Quality Tilt (2.74 per cent), FMCG (2.54 per cent), Financial Services (2.49 per cent),

HIGHLIGHTS

- » Investors shifted to a risk-off mode following pre-earnings anxiety over sluggish first-quarter forecasts
- » The 30-share BSE Sensex tanked 1,677.12 points, or 2.15 per cent
- » On BSE, 3,211 stocks declined, while 1,070 advanced and 173 remained unchanged

Bankex (2.46 per cent) and Top 10 Banks (2.34 per cent).

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, jumped 6.18 per cent to USD 78.74 per barrel.

Meanwhile, the rupee tanked 59 paise to settle at 95.55 (provisional) against the US dollar on Wednesday.

“A global equity market sell-off triggered a massive correction in domestic benchmarks as investors turned risk-averse following a fresh wave of conflict in West Asia. A strong upsurge in crude oil prices,

coupled with a sharp fall in the currency against the dollar, dampened sentiment,” Ankur Punj, MD & Business Head at Equirus Wealth, said.

Indications that a ceasefire between the US and Iran might fall apart also prompted investors to exit stocks at will, he added.

In Asian markets, South Korea’s Kospi tumbled 5.35 per cent, Japan’s Nikkei 225 index declined 2.11 per cent, and Shanghai’s SSE Composite index dipped 0.49 per cent, while Hong Kong’s Hang Seng index jumped 2.99 per cent.

European markets were trading significantly lower.

US markets ended in negative territory on Tuesday.

FIIIs bought equities worth Rs 393.19 crore on Tuesday, according to exchange data.

In the previous session, fag-end selling dragged the Sensex lower, leading the benchmark to settle 104.35 points, or 0.13 per cent, down at 78,180.72. The Nifty dipped 31.65 points, or 0.13 per cent, to end at 24,398.70.

IMF pares India’s growth forecast to 6.4% for FY27

WASHINGTON: India’s economy is expected to grow at 6.4 per cent in fiscal year 2027, a tad slower than the 6.5 per cent projected in April, the International Monetary Fund (IMF) said on Wednesday.

The IMF, in its update to the World Economic Outlook (WEO), projected India to grow at 6.7 per cent in fiscal year 2028, an increase of 20 basis points from the 6.5 per cent growth projected in April.

“India remains among the fastest growing major economies, with growth projected at 6.4 per cent supported by strong momentum in private consumption and services activity,” the IMF said.

“Factors that are underpinning the forecast revisions are basically twofold. On the upside, we have the better-than-expected out turn in the most recent data, but we also have high-frequency indicators through April showing quite a bit of resilience in overall economic activity,” Deniz Igan, Division Chief (World Economic Studies), told reporters here on projections for India.



But these positive effects are then more than offset for 2026 by the higher energy prices in the baseline and in the July update, as well as the greater pass-through of those higher oil prices to prices at the pump in India, she said.

“Moving into 2027, the IMF expects a strengthening of the economy with the energy shock dissipating and medium-term growth being estimated at around 6.5 per cent, and output closing we expect some pickup there,” Igan added.

Global growth is projected to be 3 per cent in 2026 and 3.4 per cent in 2027, down from the average of 3.5 per cent observed in 2024–25 and broadly unchanged on a cumu-

The IMF, in its update to the World Economic Outlook projected India to grow at 6.7% in FY 2028

lative basis compared with the forecasts in April.

The modest slowdown reflects the effects of the war in the Middle East being partly offset by accelerated demand-driven momentum in the global technology cycle thanks to advances in artificial intelligence (AI) and its adoption, the IMF said. The impact varies widely based on countries’ exposure to the war and position in the technology value chain, it said.

Energy exporters outside the conflict zone benefit from favourable terms of trade, whereas economies plugged into the technology-led upturn experience stronger activity even if they are energy importers, the IMF said. AGENCIES

J’khand woos global tech giants for AI-led governance push

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI/RANCHI: In a major push to position Jharkhand as a technology-driven growth hub, Chief Minister Hemant Soren on Wednesday held a series of meetings with global technology firms and industry leaders during the National Stakeholders Consultation on Vision 2050, seeking partnerships to accelerate AI-led governance, digital infrastructure and innovation.

The consultation brought together representatives from Google, Oracle, Microsoft, IBM, AWS, Salesforce, Techstar, Leah AI, Mamys and other industry stakeholders to explore the use of emerging technologies in governance and public service delivery.

Addressing the gathering, Soren assured stakeholders of the state government’s proactive approach towards technological innovation and reiterated Jharkhand’s commitment to blending its traditional wisdom with modern technology.

In discussions with Google’s Lokesh Lohiya, the focus was on AI-enabled governance, smart healthcare, emergency response systems, language solutions and digital skilling. Google proposed an AI training and certification programme

for 3–4 lakh K-12 teachers through a three-month module and suggested signing a Statement of Intent with the state government.

Oracle’s Senior Director for Data Platform, Tausif Siddique, expressed interest in strengthening Jharkhand’s AI, cloud and digital skilling ecosystem through industry-oriented training and workforce development initiatives.

Microsoft CTO India Keshri Asthana proposed a unified AI-driven Data Intelligence Platform to integrate data across government departments and improve evidence-based decision-making and service delivery.

IBM’s Senior Advisor Tallen Kumar offered collaboration on AI-powered governance solutions in mining, healthcare, banking and cybersecurity, including a no-cost proof of concept tailored to Jharkhand’s needs.

AWS Principal AI Specialist Sachin Punyani discussed leveraging cloud and AI capabilities for digital governance, Direct Benefit Transfer systems, education and centralised decision-making dashboards.

Chief Secretary Avinash Kumar and senior state officials also participated in the discussions and addressed queries raised by stakeholders.

Rupee tanks 52 paise to close at 95.48 against USD

MUMBAI: The rupee tanked 52 paise to settle at 95.48 against the US dollar on Wednesday as the US launched fresh strikes on Iran after Tehran struck three ships in the Strait of Hormuz, pushing up crude oil prices and strengthening the dollar.

Following the strikes, global crude oil prices rose exponentially. Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, was trading higher by 6.16 per cent at USD 78.73 per barrel in futures trade. Weak domestic equity markets further weighed on the local unit, according to forex traders.

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 95.15 against the US dollar and traded in the range of 94.98–95.61 during the day. It eventually settled at 95.48, down 52 paise from its previous close. MPOST

Claims over E20 fuel damaging vehicles ‘misleading’, says ISMA

NEW DELHI: The Indian Sugar and Bio-Energy Manufacturers Association (ISMA) on Wednesday said recent claims about E20 petrol damaging vehicles, attracting insects, invalidating insurance, or involving the direct mixing of sugarcane juice with fuel were “misleading and factually incorrect.”

The industry body urged that public discourse on ethanol-blended petrol be guided by scientific evidence, verified data and official clarifications.

The Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas has said India’s Ethanol Blending Programme is scientifically validated, rigorously tested, and continuously monitored, in consultation with oil marketing companies, automakers, fuel testing agencies, and other stakeholders. The government said no incidents of engine failure or vehicle breakdown had been linked to E20 petrol since its rollout.



The ministry said fuel-grade ethanol is produced through industrial processes such as fermentation and distillation and does not resemble its original agricultural feedstock. It is made from multiple sources, including sugarcane juice, molasses, broken rice, and maize, and must meet fuel-quality standards before being blended with petrol.

ISMA said automakers, oil companies and industry bodies including the Society of Indian Automobile Manufacturers, the Federation of Indian Petroleum Industry and the Automotive Research Association of India have publicly defended E20,

saying concerns about vehicle breakdowns stem from ‘hearsay, misinformation and misunderstanding’. Industry representatives said mileage variation, where observed, was marginal, while E20 helps cut emissions, reduce oil imports, save foreign exchange and support farmer incomes.

“India’s ethanol programme is one of the country’s most successful examples of aligning energy security, farmer welfare and cleaner mobility,” ISMA Director General Deepak Ballani said in the statement.

“It is therefore important that public debate is anchored in facts and not fear.”

Ballani said E20 had been introduced through a “calibrated, science-backed process” involving the government, oil marketing companies, automakers and testing agencies and that claims the fuel was unsafe or unregulated were not supported by evidence. MPOST

India, Maldives conclude negotiations for bilateral investment treaty

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: India and the Maldives have concluded negotiations for a bilateral investment treaty (BIT), and the text is undergoing legal scrubbing before the deal is signed.

The two countries are also fast-tracking negotiations for the proposed free trade agreement (FTA).

These issues, among others, were discussed during a meeting here between the visiting Mohamed Saeed, Minister of Economic Development,

Transport and Trade of the Maldives, and Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal.

“We have seen the fast, quick progress of FTA dialogue... both sides meet almost every day. BIT is concluded. We are just seeing the legal scrubbing process,” Saeed said.

Goyal said that the relationship between the people and the businesses of the two countries is soon going to get another fillip with the signing of a BIT and later an FTA.

Both sides have reaffirmed

The two countries are also fast-tracking talks for the proposed free trade agreement (FTA), officials said

their commitment to expediting the signing of the treaty and the proposed Free Trade Agreement (FTA).

The two ministers also discussed ways to enhance collaborations in areas such as

tour-ism, startups, digital payments, and MSMEs.

BIT helps in promoting and protecting investments in each other’s countries. India has recently implemented such pacts with countries like Israel and the UAE.

The agreement is expected to pave the way for increased bilateral investments between the two countries. During April 2000 and March 2026, India received USD 250 to Rs 23,000 million in foreign direct investment (FDI) from the Maldives.

India and the Maldives con-

cluded the round of negotiations for a free trade agreement on July 7.

In a trade agreement, two countries either significantly reduce or eliminate import duties on the maximum number of goods traded between them.

The bilateral trade between the two countries rose 13.5 per cent to USD 771.76 million (exports USD 458.71 million and imports USD 313 million) in 2025–26 from USD 690 million in 2024–25.

India is the major trading

partner of the Maldives.

Indian imports from the Maldives primarily comprise scrap metals, while exports include a variety of engineering and industrial products like drugs and pharmaceuticals, radar apparatus, rock boulders, aggregates, cement, and agricultural products like rice, spices, fruits, vegetables and poultry produce.

India and the Maldives signed a trade agreement in 1981, which provides for the export of essential commodities.

Kotak Mutual Fund launches Nifty Private Bank ETF

NEW DELHI: Kotak Mahindra Asset Management Company Ltd (KMAMC/Kotak Mutual Fund) on Wednesday announced the launch of the Kotak Nifty Private Bank ETF, an open-ended exchange-traded fund that seeks to replicate and track the Nifty Private Bank Index.

The new fund offer (NFO) opened for public subscription on July 8 and will close on July 15.

The Nifty Private Bank Index tracks the performance of the top 10 private sector banks selected from the Nifty 500 universe on the basis of free-float market capitalisation. The index is rebalanced semi-annually.

Nilesh Shah, Managing Director of KMAMC, said the ETF offers investors a simple and cost-efficient way to participate in the growth of India’s leading private sector banks while providing diversified exposure to a key segment of the financial sector through a rule-based investment approach. MPOST

‘India’s energy storage requirement set to jump to 888 GWh by 2035–36’

India’s installed BESS capacity increased 11-fold in 6 months to 8.7 GWh

NEW DELHI: India will require 888 GWh of energy storage system capacity by 2035–36, up from 1 GWh currently, according to an industry report released on Wednesday. The report highlighted how energy storage is now the key pillar in strengthening grid reliability and enabling the country’s renewable energy ambitions, a statement said.

India will require 888 GWh of energy storage system (ESS) capacity by 2035–36, from the existing 1 GWh scale, according to the ‘India BESS Market Review’ released by India Energy Storage Alliance (IESA) and Customized Energy Solutions (CES) at India Energy Storage Week (IESW) here on Wednesday.

The inaugural session of IESW 2026 featured industry leaders and delegates from 15 countries.

Debmalya Sen, President of IESA, said on the occasion that the IESW 2026 is more than an industry summit; it’s a testament to how far India has come on its clean energy journey.



INSIGHT

- » By ‘30, Cell/pack to container capacity is expected to reach 180–200 GWh
- » India is recognised as one of world’s fastest-growing BESS markets

The 888 GWh target by 2035–36 signals a new era where energy storage is at the centre of our energy ambitions, Sen added.

Organised by IESA, the three-day event at Yashobhoori (IICC) brings together over 200 exhibitors and more than 10,000 industry leaders for policy discussion, technical exchange, and announcements that will define India’s clean energy transition.

Radiance Renewables CEO Nitin Bhatia said he believes solar plus battery energy storage is the way forward.

The report further shows that India’s installed BESS

capacity increased 11-fold in just six months, from 0.78 GWh in December 2025 to 8.7 GWh in H1 2026, and the country is on track to surpass 10 GWh of installed BESS capacity by the end of the year. In H1 2026, 47 GWh of ESS tenders were floated, bringing the total tender pipeline to 260 GWh.

Tanya Singhal, Vice President, Country Head - India, Global Energy Alliance for People and Planet, said that to build a truly flexible and resilient grid, storage must be integrated at the generation, transmission, distribution, and consumption levels.

Eighteen BESS projects have been commissioned so far, with 70 per cent of the capacity addition in H1 2026 coming from merchant BESS installations.

India’s manufacturing momentum is also accelerating, with current Li-ion battery cell manufacturing capacity at around 2 GWh and announced targets of approximately 110 GWh by 2030.

Cell/pack to container capacity is expected to reach 180–200 GWh by 2030.

Venugopal Rao Maddisetty, Chairman and Managing Director, Pace Digitek, said that energy storage is now an indispensable national infrastructure, enabling renewable energy to become dispatchable, stabilising the grid, and enhancing resilience.

The report underscores that, despite global supply chain volatility and rising battery prices, India’s BESS sector has demonstrated remarkable resilience and is now recognised as one of the world’s fastest-growing markets. AGENCIES

NEW DELHI: Markets regulator Sebi has replaced the existing US dollar-denominated registration fee for Foreign Portfolio Investors (FPIs) with a rupee-based fee structure.

To implement the change, the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) has amended the rules governing FPIs. The revised provisions will come into effect after six months, Sebi said in its notification dated July 3.

As per the notification, the regulator has revised the registration fee for Category-I FPIs from USD 2,500 to Rs 2.3 lakh. Similarly, registration fee for FPIs belonging to Category II has been revised from USD 250 to Rs 23,000. The regulator has also revised the application fee for seeking general relaxations or exemptions from strict enforcement of regulations from USD 1,000 to Rs 90,000 in eligible foreign exchange equivalent.

The markets watchdog has also updated the common application form used for FPI registration. MPOST

BKS, Manav Rachna Univ join hands to promote Indian Knowledge System

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Bharat Ki Soch (BKS) and the Manav Rachna Centre for Peace & Sustainability (MRCPS), Manav Rachna University, have signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) to promote the Indian Knowledge System (IKS) as a framework for sustainable development, civic responsibility and national progress.

The partnership aims to integrate classical Indian wisdom with modern academic and policy frameworks to support the country’s journey towards a Viksit Bharat. All joint initiatives and research outputs will be undertaken under the joint branding of BKS and MRCPS.

Speaking on the occasion, BKS Chairperson Anil Rajput said meaningful national transformation must begin at the grassroots, particularly with students and children, who can act as catalysts for sustainable growth and character-building. He stressed that development should be measured not only by eco-



nomic progress but also by the happiness and well-being of citizens.

Manav Rachna University Vice Chancellor Prof. Deependra Kumar Jha said ancient Indic principles offer valuable solutions to contemporary challenges and should be embedded in modern education and policymaking.

The collaboration will focus on six key areas, including health, environmental sustainability, ethical governance, civic responsibility, national security, conscious capitalism and climate-resilient agricultural systems, while producing research papers and policy briefs on identified themes.

A rematch made in heaven

Morocco offer France first real test of World Cup credentials

EAST RUTHERFORD: France's World Cup campaign has already tested their fire-power, patience and nerves, but Thursday's quarterfinal against Morocco will offer Didier Deschamps' side something different: their first full football examination of the tournament.

The meeting is a rematch of the 2022 World Cup semi-final, when France ended Morocco's historic run in Qatar, but this time the North Africans arrive not as surprise outsiders but as a confident, gifted side who have been open about their ambition to win the tournament.

France reached the last eight after a 1-0 win over Paraguay, a game that demanded character and patience more than fluency. Paraguay sat deep, slowed the rhythm and forced France to find a way through a packed defensive structure. Deschamps' team did enough, with Kylian Mbappe scoring his seventh goal at this World Cup, but the performance also underlined that the knock-out stage is beginning to ask harder questions of a side whose attacking talent has carried them through much of the tournament.

Against Morocco, the challenge will be different. Mohamed



France's players jog during a training session

AFP

Ouahbi's side have shown they can suffer, control spells of possession and punish opponents with speed and precision.

Their 3-0 win over Canada in the last 16 confirmed the impression of a team growing into the tournament after coming through the group stage unbeaten. Morocco had already shown their level in a demanding group, collecting seven points from matches against Brazil, Scotland and Haiti, and their performances have backed up their stated belief that they are not merely

12
Mbappé has made two assists and created 12 chances for France at this World Cup

here to repeat the emotional charge of 2022.

France, by contrast, have yet to face a side with Morocco's blend of technical quality, athletic intensity and self-belief. Sweden were brushed aside in the last 32, while Paraguay provided resistance without posing the same footballing threat Morocco are likely to bring. The match should offer the clearest indication yet of whether France's attacking quartet can continue to bend the tournament to their will against opponents capable of hurting them in transition and testing their defence.

AGENCIES

More bliss for Swiss

VANCOUVER: In a match with few fireworks, the Swiss were patient against the Colombians and their enthusiastic fans.

After a scoreless draw, Ruben Vargas converted the decisive penalty and Switzerland advanced to the World Cup quarterfinals, beating Colombia 4-3 in a shootout on Tuesday.

Switzerland will face defending champion Argentina on Saturday at Arrowhead Stadium in Kansas City, Missouri. Argentina defeated Egypt 3-2 earlier in the day.

Switzerland had not reached the quarterfinals of a World Cup since hosting the tournament in 1954. And the Swiss were short-handed Tuesday without young midfielder Johan Manzambi, who was injured in training on Monday. Vargas, who has scored two goals in the World Cup, also left Monday's training early but came on in stoppage time at the end of regulation.

AGENCIES

MESSI TAKES LEAD IN GOLDEN BOOT RACE Tears, cheers & Messi magic: Argentina bask in afterglow

ATLANTA: Lionel Messi let the tears flow at the final whistle, succumbing to emotion after Argentina conjured up an incredible two-goal comeback to beat Egypt 3-2 on Tuesday and advance to the World Cup quarterfinals.

Argentina's three goals came in the final 11 minutes of regulation and injury time. Messi played a direct hand — or foot — in two of them.

Messi helped get Argentina on the board in the 79th minute, assisting on Cristian Romero's header. Four minutes later, he levelled the match at 2-2, drilling a shot past Egypt goalkeeper Mostafa Shobeir.

A sold-out crowd at Mercedes-Benz Stadium, made up of mostly Argentina's signature blue and white, erupted. And no one was surprised it was Messi who paved the way to victory.

"Watching Leo run the way he does, just pushing himself further every day — I just told him that he deserved it. He's our role model, our guide — the one who helps us at all times," Argentina forward Lautaro Martinez said. "This team is incredible. It never gives up. It keeps trying until the very end."

Messi's goal was his eighth of this year's World Cup and



Lionel Messi is emotional after their win over Egypt

AP

extended his scoring streak to a record nine consecutive World Cup matches dating back to Argentina's title run in 2022. Tuesday's goal was his 13th in that nine-game span.

In the race for his first Golden Boot, Messi entered Tuesday's match even with France's Kylian Mbappé and Norway's Erling Haaland at seven goals each.

Mbappé held the tiebreaker with two assists. England's Harry Kane is also in the running with six goals.

The score also gave Messi a two-goal lead over Mbappé on the all-time World Cup

leaderboard.

Messi finished second in the Golden Boot race behind Mbappé in 2022 with seven goals while leading Argentina to the title in Qatar. He tied for third with four goals in 2014.

Messi's impact on this year's World Cup run, teammate Julián Alvarez said, is hard to put into words.

"Leo, honestly, there aren't really words to describe this Cup run," Alvarez said. "What he's doing is incredible, and we just try to help him, support him, and enjoy every moment alongside him. We're also grateful for everything he does for us and for the kind of person he is."

AGENCIES

'NEED TO ADAPT BETTER', SAYS GAMBHIR

Struggling India look to end UK nightmare

BRISTOL: Faced with selection dilemmas and struggling to adapt in hostile conditions, the Shreyas Iyer-led India have their task cut out when they take on England in the series-deciding fourth T20 International here on Thursday.

India slumped to their heaviest-ever T20I defeat in terms of runs, losing by 125 to England in the third T20I on Tuesday. The visitors are now 0-2 down in the five-match series. This comes after a maiden bilateral series defeat to Ireland last month.

“We haven’t adapted well. Whether it was in Ireland or here in England, that has been the reality

Gautam Gambhir

The biggest selection conundrum surrounds Sanju Samson, who was dropped

from the second and third T20I in favour of 15-year-old swash-buckler Vaibhav Sooryavanshi.

The teenager has not done any worse or better than the rest of the team so far and given that the side is trailing 0-2 right now, India head coach Gautam Gambhir has not ruled out Samson's return. In a matter of four months, Samson's career has swung from darkness to dizzying heights, only to return to square one.

Gambhir comes to defence
India's T20 squad is in transition following a "reset",

declared Gambhir as he attributed the horrendous run in the UK to an acute lack of game awareness and failure to read the conditions correctly.

"We just haven't played well," Gambhir said at the post-match press conference here.

"There are a lot of changes from the XI that played the T20 World Cup final to now. Be it the captain, be it the opening batsman, there is no Jasprit Bumrah," he later pointed out. When you go for that reset, it takes a bit of time."

AGENCIES

It Augers well: Djokovic wins marathon contest

LONDON: Side to side. Corner to corner. Novak Djokovic kept pushing Felix Auger-Aliassime back and forth along the Centre Court baseline at Wimbledon to retrieve one shot after another.

Finally, on the 22nd shot of a grueling rally deep in a fifth-set super tiebreaker, Auger-Aliassime had a forehand in the middle of the court. Under normal circumstances it might have been just the shot he was looking for.

Not this time. Not after five hours of battling with the 39-year-old Djokovic.

Auger-Aliassime, a 25-year-



Novak Djokovic beat Felix Auger-Aliassime in five hours to reach semis

AP

old Canadian with one of the top-rated forehands on tour, had nothing left in his tank.

He sprayed his forehand wide to give Djokovic a 9-4 lead. Then both players bent over in

exhaustion and leaned on their rackets. Djokovic, while he was bent over, still found energy to encourage the crowd to cheer louder, waving his right arm for more noise.

One point later, the longest quarterfinal in Wimbledon history — at 5 hours and 15 minutes — was finished.

"These," Djokovic said, "are the kind of moments that I still play tennis for." Djokovic, the seven-time Wimbledon champion, prevailed 7-6 (10), 3-6, 6-3, 6-7 (4), 7-6 (4) on Tuesday to set up a semifinal against defending champion Jannik Sinner.

AGENCIES

Leisure

FIRST LOOK ON SOURAV GANGULY'S B'DAY

RAJKUMMAR RECREATES SOURAV GANGULY'S ICONIC LORD'S MOMENT IN 'DADA' FIRST LOOK

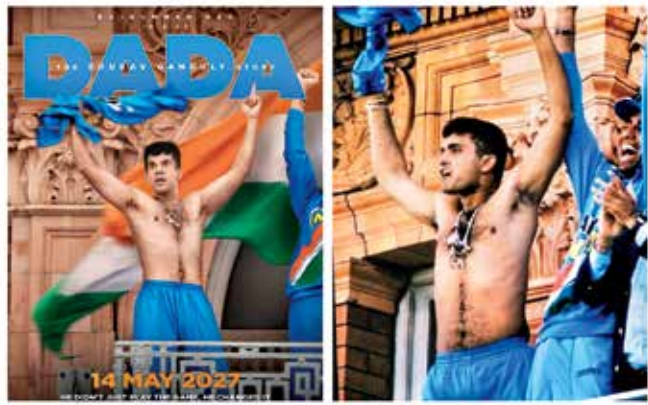
The biopic will hit the theatres on May 14, 2027

OUR CORRESPONDENT

The wait is over for Sourav Ganguly fans. The much-awaited first look of 'Dada: The Sourav Ganguly Story' featuring Rajkummar Rao was unveiled on Wednesday, on the ex-Indian cricket captain's 54th birthday, making the day even more special for millions of fans across the world. Along with the reveal, the makers also announced the film's theatrical release on May 14, 2027, over an extended holiday weekend.

The official first-look poster captures Rajkummar in a cinematic recreation of Ganguly's iconic jersey-waving moment at Lord's balcony following India's historic NatWest Trophy triumph over England in 2002. Widely regarded as one of the most iconic images in cricket, the celebration came to symbolise a fearless new era of Indian cricket under Ganguly's leadership and remains an enduring emblem of confidence, defiance and belief. Sharing the look, Rajkummar Rao wrote, "Happy Birthday, our dearest Dada."

Ganguly, who in an interview said that Rajkummar is the best choice to



While Bollywood celebrities praised the first look, it didn't impress the netizens and fans of Sourav Ganguly

play him onscreen, also shared the poster and wrote, "The Best Gift Ever! Can't wait to see you play my cover drive! @rajkummar_rao (sic)"

Even a month back, director Vikramaditya Motwane was in Kolkata at the ex-Indian cricketer's Behala home and shot several crucial portions of the film in the City of Joy. Bengali actress Aparajita Auddy will be seen playing Nirupa Ganguly, the cricketer's mother, in the film. Saswata Chatterjee will be seen as his father, Chandu Ganguly and actor Rahul Dev Bose will be seen playing Dada's brother Snehashish Ganguly. Rajkummar shot several scenes in and around Kolkata, including at the

famous Eden Gardens.

Now, the makers might have rightly chosen Ganguly's Lord's moment as the first look of the biopic, but then the netizens and fans of Dada aren't really impressed. While members of Bollywood like Ayushmann Khurrana (who was reportedly in the race to play Ganguly on screen), Ali Fazal, Patralekha, Neha Dhupia and Aparshakti Khurana praised Rajkummar's look, the netizens raised concerns.

"Official poster backlash button," posted one user. Several users mentioned that even 'ChatGPT' could have done a better job. Some criticised the poster being made with artificial intelligence (AI). A user wrote, "Even fan-made posters have better efforts and effects than this." "Need a better poster. Also, frankly, I needed another actor. He hardly looks like you," wrote another user. A die-hard Ganguly fan wrote, "One of the worst posters I have seen. Dada deserves better."

Only the first look of the biopic has been unveiled and here's hoping the makers will do justice to the journey of Ganguly, one of India's most successful cricket captains.

Manoj Bajpayee launches 'Uttar Da Puttar' trailer

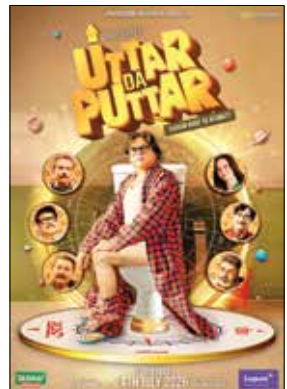
The film introduces a quirky tale of faith and fate

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Acclaimed actor Manoj Bajpayee, known for his content-driven films and for supporting meaningful cinema, launched the official trailer of 'Uttar Da Puttar', giving audiences a first look at the upcoming comedy-drama. The trailer introduces a quirky story that blends humour, family emotions and an unusual take on faith, fate and the search for the right direction.

Annu Kapoor leads the film as a man whose life begins to change after he becomes convinced that the right direction can alter his destiny. As he tries to find answers through faith and belief, a series of unexpected and humorous incidents unfold, bringing together an entertaining mix of laughter, emotions and family relationships.

The film also stars Rukhsar Rehman, Brijendra Kala, Pavan Malhotra, Ishitiyak Khan, Jeeveshu Ahluwalia, Rajendra Sethi, Sumit Gulati and Nitin Arora in key roles, bringing together an ensemble cast that adds to the film's colourful world.



The film also stars Rukhsar Rehman, Brijendra Kala and others

Produced by Sandeep Kapur and Priya Kapur under the banner of 'Promodome Motion Pictures', 'Uttar Da Puttar' is written and directed by Ravinder Siwach and is based on a story by Sandeep Kapur.

Speaking about the trailer, producer Sandeep Kapur said, "We are happy to have Manoj Bajpayee launch the trailer of 'Uttar Da Puttar'. His encour-

agement means a lot to the entire team. The film is a family entertainer with humour at its core, but it also carries a simple message about the choices people make while searching for happiness and success. We hope audiences enjoy what they see in the trailer."

Director Ravinder Siwach said, "The trailer introduces the world of 'Uttar Da Puttar' and the characters who bring this story to life. While it gives viewers a glimpse of the fun and humour, there is much more waiting in the film. We are looking forward to bringing it to audiences in theatres."

Carrying forward the film's central thought, 'Karam Bade Ya Kismat?', the trailer explores whether life is shaped by our actions or by destiny, while keeping the storytelling light-hearted and entertaining.

Known for backing content-driven films such as 'Jugaad', 'Anaarkali of Aarah' and the National Award-winning 'Bhonsle', 'Promodome Motion Pictures' continues its tradition of bringing distinctive stories to audiences with 'Uttar Da Puttar'.

Yash & Kiara's love story in 'Toxic' feels all-consuming

OUR CORRESPONDENT

The song is a poignant portrayal of yearning, restraint and unspoken emotions

Some love stories begin with a confession. "Tabaahi" chooses silence instead. Featuring Yash and Kiara Advani, the first song from 'Toxic: A Fairy Tale for Grown-Ups' is a poignant portrayal of yearning, restraint and unspoken emotions. Composed and sung by Vishal Mishra, the haunting melody and soulful

vocals beautifully elevate every lingering glance between the two, making their unspoken connection with the true heartbeat of the song.

Throughout the video, Yash and Kiara's moments together are filled with an undeniable pull. Every shared glance carries the weight of yearning, while every silence feels heavier than a conversation. Rather than relying on dramatic declarations, "Tabaahi"

Directed by Geetu Mohandas, the film has a powerhouse ensemble featuring Nayanthara, Rukmini Vasanth and Huma Qureshi

embraces emotional restraint, making their connection feel

even more all-consuming.

One of the music video's most striking moments comes when Tara Sutaria's character, Rebecca, asks Raya (Yash), "You can't love anyone other than yourself?" His response is immediate: "Not a chance." On the surface, it sounds like certainty, a man convinced that love has no place in his life. But in the very next moments, that conviction quietly unravels.

The camera cuts to Raya looking at Kiara and in that single glance, words become irrelevant. His eyes betray everything he refuses to admit. The longing, the hesitation and the quiet vulnerability suggest a man trying to outrun emotions that have already taken hold.

'Toxic' has a powerhouse ensemble featuring Nayanthara, Rukmini Vasanth and Huma Qureshi.



PHYSICAL POSSESSION NOTICE

Branch Office: ICICI Bank Limited Plot No-23, Shal Tower, 3rd Floor, New Rohtak Road, Karol Bagh, New Delhi- 110005

The Authorised ICICI Bank Officer under the Securitisation, Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of the powers conferred under section 13(12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002, issued Demand Notices to the borrower(s) mentioned below, to repay the amount mentioned in the Notice within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said Notice.

Having failed to repay the amount, the Notice is issued to the borrower and the public in general that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described below, by exercising powers conferred on him/her under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said rules on the below-mentioned dates. The borrower in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with the property. Any dealings with the property will be subject to charges of ICICI Bank Limited.

Sr. No.	Name of the Borrower(s)/ Loan Account Number	Description of Property/ Date of Physical Possession	Date of Demand Notice/ Amount in Demand Notice (Rs)	Name of Branch
1.	M/s. Econ/ Arun Kumar Gupta/ Arpit Gupta/ 0718050003378	Residential Property Bearing Plot/House No. A/64, Measuring area 239.425 Sq. Mtrs (Covered Area-20.00 Sq. Mtrs), Situated At Block-A, Sector-4, T.H.A. Residential Colony, Lajpat Nagar, Ghaziabad, Tehsil & District Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh, 201007. Owned By Arun Kumar Gupta (Addressing An Area of 239.425 Sq. Mtrs. North, House No. A-43 South; Road 25 Feet Wide East; House No.A-63 West; House No. A-65./ Date of Physical Possession July 03, 2026	October 15,2025 Rs. 3,19,03,355.69/-	Ghaziabad

The above-mentioned borrowers(s)/guarantors(s) is/are hereby issued a 30 day Notice to repay the amount, else the mortgaged properties will be sold after 30 days from the date of publishing this Notice, as per the provisions under Rules 8 and 9 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002.

Date: July 09, 2026
Place: Ghaziabad

Sincerely Authorised Officer
For ICICI Bank Ltd.

SYMBOLIC POSSESSION NOTICE

Branch Office: ICICI Bank Limited Plot No-23, Shal Tower, 3rd Floor, New Rohtak Road, Karol Bagh, New Delhi- 110005

The Authorised ICICI Bank Officer under the Securitisation, Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of the powers conferred under section 13(12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002, issued Demand Notices to the borrower(s) mentioned below, to repay the amount mentioned in the Notice within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said Notice.

Having failed to repay the amount, the Notice is issued to the borrower and the public in general that the undersigned has taken symbolic possession of the property described below, by exercising powers conferred on him/her under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said rules on the below-mentioned dates. The borrower in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with the property. Any dealings with the property will be subject to charges of ICICI Bank Limited.

Sr. No.	Name of the Borrower(s)/ Loan Account Number	Description of Property/ Date of Symbolic Possession	Date of Demand Notice/ Amount in Demand Notice (Rs)	Name of Branch
1.	Arun Raman/ Jai Shree Raman/ LBHG200004979847	Unit No 435, Floor 4, DDA LIG Flat Kondli Gharoli, Mayur Vihar, Phase 3, Delhi 110096/ July 06, 2026	June 19,2025 Rs. 20,52,799/-	Delhi NCR

The above-mentioned borrowers(s)/guarantors(s) is/are hereby issued a 30 day Notice to repay the amount, else the mortgaged properties will be sold after 30 days from the date of publishing this Notice, as per the provisions under Rules 8 and 9 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002.

Date: July 09, 2026
Place: Delhi/NCR

Sincerely Authorised Officer,
For ICICI Bank Ltd.

RAIL COACH FACTORY
KAPURTHALA

For and on behalf of the President of India, the Principal Chief Materials Manager, Rail Coach Factory invites e-tenders for supply of the following items:-

Sr. No.	Tender No. and Due Date	Description	Quantity (Nos./Sets)	EMD (Rs.)
1.	05261380 31.07.2026	Set of SS trough with Mounting Items for LHB Bangladesh First AC Coaches.	PI No. 33512796 68 Set	1,60,480/-
2.	05261472 31.07.2026	3 Types of set of Carline for Bangladesh Coach.	PI No. 33532291 33559077 28 Set 19 Set	1,39,810/-
3.	14261065 30.07.2026	PVC flooring Roll for Bangladesh Coaches.	235 Nos.	1,96,080/-
4.	17261224 05.08.2026	Set of floor plate for AC Power Car of Bangladesh Railway.	28 Sets	1,36,800/-
5.	17261241 04.08.2026	Air Inlet Duct Complete Mounting for BG Air Conditioned Chair Car (WJCC).	42 Set	2,32,300/-
6.	12261168 03.08.2026	Air Inlet Duct Complete for FAC (WJC) Bangladesh Railways.	27 Set	2,93,050/-
7.	12261197 03.08.2026	Fixing Arrangement of Rolling Shutter Assembly for 3-Phase MEMU/DMC & MEMU/TC (2 Types).	733 Nos.	1,36,800/-
8.	12261197 03.08.2026	Composite fire Extinguishers, 1000 Nos. with ANTI-THEFT Mechanism.	141 Nos.	9,60,000/-
9.	07261111 29.07.2026	Honey Comb Partition Frame Set with AL FR HPL Sheet for LHB SCN Amrit Bharat 3.0 Coaches.	96 Set	3,93,990/-
10.	07261109 31.07.2026	Set of Pipe & Pipe Fittings of Control Equipment for 3-Phase MEMU/DMC & TC Coaches with MEDHA Electric.	560 Set	7,46,130/-
11.	01261147 29.07.2026	Set of Pipe & Pipe Fittings (Bogie) for Air Brake Set of 145 PH DMC Coach.	135 Set	1,56,660/-
12.	01261149 30.07.2026	Set of Pipe & Pipe Fittings (Bogie) for Air Brake Set of 3PH TC Coach.	306 Set	1,71,980/-
13.	05261448 29.07.2026	Bogie Bolster within Built Reservoir for MEMU.	1038 Nos.	13,63,040/-
14.	07261151 30.07.2026	Bogie Bolster for LHB Coaches.	216 Nos.	4,71,530/-
15.	07261104 30.07.2026	Set of Body Side Doors for LHB Supply, Installation, Commissioning & Testing of Stainless Steel Tubes and Double Ferrule Fittings for LHB NON-AC Hot Buffet Car Coaches.	37 Set	1,71,980/-
16.	07261127 30.07.2026	Supply of Stainless Steel Tubes And Double Ferrule Fittings for 3 Phase MEMU/ TC Coaches Supply of Stainless Steel Tubes And Double Ferrule Fittings for 3 Phase MEMU/DMC.	288 Set 55 Set	10,55,390/-
17.	07261123 30.07.2026	Supply, Installation, Commissioning & Testing of Stainless Steel Tubes & Double Ferrule Fittings for LGS Coaches.	142 Set	8,29,330/-
18.	07261203 30.07.2026	Stainless Steel Tubes & Double Ferrule Fittings for LHB Chair Car.	53 Set	2,06,960/-
19.	01261140 05.08.2026	Air Spring 180 KN for LHB Coaches.	462 Sets	3,38,370/-
20.	05261346 31.07.2026	Centering Disc	1096 Nos.	1,36,260/-
21.	01261183 05.08.2026	Set of Doorway Partition for MEMU/DMC/3PH Set of Control Arms (Finished) for LHB Bogies.	387 Sets 1571 Set	8,50,730/- 20,00,000/-

1. For details and making On-line bids, visit Website <http://ireps.gov.in>. Drawings/specifications, wherever required can be downloaded from RCF Website <http://www.rcf.indianrailways.gov.in>. Class IIIB digital signature certificate required for on-line bidding, can be obtained from licensed certifying agencies listed at <http://www.cce.gov.in>.

2. Tenders will close at 14:30 HRS on due date and tender will be opened at 14:30 HRS. Tenders Sr. No. 1 to 8 will be opened at RCF, Kapurthala (Punjab) & Tenders Sr. No. 9 to 21 will be opened at Tilak Bridge, New Delhi.

3. Tenderers are advised to submit the tender cost online through Electronic Mode Through Payment Gateway/Facility on the IREPS Website.

4. For queries contact IREPS Helpdesk at 011-24102855, 011-24105180 or RCF helpdesk at 011-23378658.

Note: GST Number of RCF is 03AAAGM0289C1ZT. All the suppliers are advised to quote this in dispatch documents for the supplies made by them.

PCMM CORRIENDUM:The following amendments are authorized against (1) Tender No. 01261105 for procurement of PAD for Secondary Suspension. Due date may be read as 14.07.2026 instead of 06.07.2026. (2) Tender No.: 12251278A due on 20/07/2026 for procurement of Inter-coach Gangway Including Vestibule Foot Plate Without Flexible Interior System Furnishing for LHB (Amrit Bharat) Coaches to PL No. 33566811. Due date may be read as 20.07.2026 instead of 06.07.2026. (3)Tender No.: 17261018A due on 06/07/2026 for procurement of Design, Supply, Installation & Commissioning of Interior Furnishing items of One rake set for HS-SPART. Due date may be read as 16.07.2026 instead of 06.07.2026. (4)Tender No.: 02261233 due on 06/07/2026 for procurement of C.D.S.I.C. Maintenance Manuals, Spares & Maintenance work of Onboard Condition Monitoring System (OBMS). Changes in Clauses: Quantity, Existing: 152 to be read as 64.

PCMM
R.O. No. 37-S/2026-27
Dated: 08.07.2026

सोहा रियल्टी प्राइवेट लिमिटेड

Corp. Address :- B-27, Ground Floor, Vipul Plaza, Sector-81, Faridabad, Haryana-121002

License No./Year: 125 of 2024 dated 23.10.2024, RERA No. - HRERA-PKL-FBD-705-2025 Dated : 27.05.2025, Project ID : 218

ऑनलाइन ई-ब्रा टिनांक 06 जुलाई 2026, सोमवार कार्यालय सिनियर टाऊन प्लानर, द्वितीय तल, हुड्डा कमप्लेक्स, सेक्टर-12, फरीदाबाद में आयोजित सोहा रियल्टी प्राइवेट लिमिटेड, सेक्टर-81, फरीदाबाद स्थित प्लेटों के झा के सफल आवेदकों की सूची।

SUCCESSFUL APPLICATION LIST (1 BHK)

324415	327590	323672	323474	330009	328785	327985	325876	324383	323482	328938	318053	338665	327355
326144	319797	325198	329853	325707	331466	331403	321405	319729	327387	319187	325015	327718	338458
318150	325353	315620	327042	328664	316714	337200	330979	338912	331308	329509	324220	316416	330369
323415	324140	331164	315433	330789	329097	319473	324136	330968	329319	316664	324869	327318	327683
337797	324295	316689	320327	331500	326856	338290	330515	338425	318937	330303	324553	316992	330275
325646	329708	330690	326352	330339	324373	324014	325676	338170	331120	331176	338457	326522	338526
323495	330175	323906	325982	329918	327850	322282	328012	339077	327493	326504	329405	318994	331286
324622	315809	328306	323687	327212	328045	319419	325226	326710	316091	323615	326678	322726	315701
325331	329426	323913	316948	330334	327244	330897	327389	326668	324697	324111	329337	327809	338011
319158	324975	330282	323470	324060	323508	336952	325263	323835	338109	319580	329149	327737	328000
324166	316372	324703	323999	315430	316981	325381	316934	324387	323850	327421	324210	330254	325309
330484	323751	325453	326163	326972	316524	326387	318982	318632	316107	327004	329407	331044	315647

SUCCESSFUL APPLICATION LIST (2 BHK)

338693	327054	318323	328793	338902	318487	327329	329691	324094	328741	319599	317093	338954	324749	331084
328611	330052	325296	331483	329414	331239	328472	337741	324958	330243	329103	327581	326400	329096	324670
338230	330481	322908	324657	323979	316967	329398	320292	327719	321120	323493	321666	339143	326399	319468
331255	330123	326060	328593	325712	320879	317982	327627	331147	327750	317817	316483	327832	323488	320272
324150	321134	318512	327271	318649	330534	329608	324330	324053	317216	331463	325250	329589	325217	338300
330322	317291	325105	328918	328069	317823	328749	321210	325264	326308	318281	324455	329696	331000	316455
315680	330373	328828	328318	316507	324189	338392	323009	323512	336709	321910	327970	326920	328943	331012
317662	328334	325269	315979	325300	331338	328231	329582	337533	338579	316742	327504	326184	315574	328205
330632	328754	339003	330152	327475	325029	331343	328070	317936	317894	327966	329083	320416	327949	325966
323589	323874	338032	330237	324025	316971	325087	324361	325898	318841	326596	331490	326929	329451	331701
324143	326205	321864	328228	330611	319410	325533	327190	328980	328222	326575	329195	330643	330766	329073
328382	316439	331342	329417	325531	317067	328050	329285	338370	323837	326684	326877	327630	329594	326662
323847	324781	326929	326492	337378	328528	318297	329102	328209	327931	330861	325988	324978	325649	326937
329945	326954	324235	329502	323715	317261	327337	327418	326485	325030	318706	329191	330231	316956	318642
318207	320330	337847	328852	331468	324090	329148	323691	338601	316037	325815	316574	327052	324898	326076
330891	327986	329826	329827	327477	325544	325774	324666	315910	316661	328197	326562	325407	325972	326688
325336	327213	315598	328050	330450	328706	328601	325807	326798	325463	318341	320897	331418	329588	325239
326648	319059	321314	338438	329276	325451	315897	324832	317930	331491	324159	326516	316392	318941	329033
318214	326927	327575	338341	324278	327415	326110	316573	328710	317618	320957	323417	322611	329614	321665
328293	326899	324884	331228	331501	338473	329525	323456	317764	327096	315936	327653	316413	330331	325904
325705	325141	338477	319724	325402	325589	324271	330696	326107	338373	327285	330428	326495	325559	327288
329872	316462	329476	326542	325048	338539	330173	329739	329861	326452	325587	325592	331396	326430	321157
325345	323747	326848	319879	327273	324893	327714	317977	320773	321148	326928	329457	324148	329457	328715
330575	315790	330868	320490	325685	319456	324569	330680	328432	327735	327889	318583	325283	325364	320145
330965	316648	316465	329267	324291	327051	318270	316207	328603	324612	323854	327253	324912	318646	324026
326100	325872	325367	324423	316993	316590	329473	318357	327170	317529	329133	329332	332764	339107	326846
337274	321845	316566	320297	320698	330139	324231	323616	325118	330666	327113	318601	325090	321885	329624
327512	326209	329609	326327	324700	324949	320086	324119	325761	316198	316939	315999	315564	320780	325370
319083	324594	322821	325682	331393	331039	325307	324086	325560	316011	330980	329865	317319	327280	319196
317566	317833	324461	318070	325690	337927	330305	319077	316405	326832	329966	317680	318011	325558	326338
324821	325696	319804	331113	325730	325557	330364	338128	329690	327317	327405	323618	323433	321182	327111
329990	330936	326459	324299	325351	330681	324187	329636	332568	316920	328774	326489	317584	327028	327028
327976	330794	338123	322202	316623	319499	327144	329030	330277	324687	331045	328752	330333	325884	326776
328007	324068	329145	328066	323643	326383	328370	325013	317243	318354	318609	324332	326066	321189	329440
324497	325523	317637	327454	323891	319519	327973	331029	325765	324336	328688	330833	326270	331421	319256
316783	31													

**AROUND THE WORLD**

- » Three Haryana universities sign MoUs to advance research and academic exchange
- » East Point Engineering students develop AI-powered nutrition system
- » WUD launches future-ready theatre programmes for India's expanding creative economy
- » Result of CA intermediate examination held in May 2026 declared

**BUZZER ROUND**

Q) WHO SCORED THE MOST GOALS IN MEN'S WORLD CUP HISTORY?

Send us your replies to careersmp22@gmail.com. We shall publish the names of the first 3 correct entries in next week's edition

Answer to our July 2 edition question: **Craig Gordon**

Correct answers were sent by: **Rashid Parwez, Mahua Sengupta, Amit Chakraborty**

**NEWS & VIEWS**

According to the latest All India Survey on Higher Education (AISHE) released by the Union Ministry of Education, more young people are entering colleges and universities in India, with total enrolment in higher education reaching 4.5 crore in 2023-24. The number of teachers in higher education institutions also increased.

IIT Bangalore hosted its 26th annual convocation recently. The ceremony was graced by chief guest, Prof Rajat Moona, Director of the IIT Gandhinagar; Guest of Honour, Dr V Veerappan, Cofounder and President, Tessolve Semiconductor & Chairman ELCITA. The ceremony was presided over by the IIIT-Bangalore Governing Body Chairman, Padma Bhushan Kris Gopalakrishnan in the presence of Dr Debabrata Das, Director of IIIT-Bangalore.

AT 17, J&K STUDENT CREATES RS 5 CR AI EDTECH VENTURE

Imran Chaudhary's learning platform offers AI-powered study assistance, quizzes, doubt-solving and career guidance

OUR CORRESPONDENT

At an age when most teenagers are preparing for board examinations and planning their college admissions, 17-year-old Imran Chaudhary from Jammu and Kashmir has achieved a remarkable milestone by building an artificial intelligence (AI) startup valued at Rs 5 crore within just six months.

A Class 12 student from Doongi village in Rajouri district, Imran is the founder of Lagnever Technologies Private Ltd, an edtech startup that leverages AI to make learning more personalised and accessible for students.

According to the company, its flagship product, Lagnever AI, has surpassed 10,000 downloads since its launch. The platform offers a variety of AI-powered learning tools designed to complement classroom education rather than replace teachers. Its features include AI-assisted study support, automated note generation, quizzes, doubt-solving assistance, and career guidance, enabling students to learn



REPRESENTATIVE PICTURE

more effectively alongside conventional teaching methods.

Imran said his vision is to create a platform that improves access to quality education, especially for

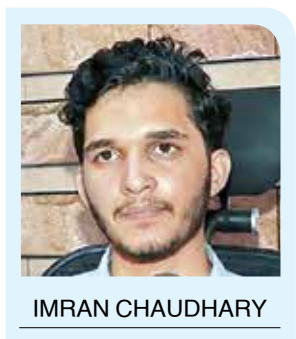
students who do not have access to premium learning resources.

Although Imran leads the startup, he attributes its rapid growth to the efforts of his 12-member team. He

said that growing up in a remote village with limited resources never discouraged his interest in technology. Instead, it inspired him to learn on his own and work towards building an

educational platform that could benefit students across India.

The startup has also begun attracting strong



IMRAN CHAUDHARY

investor interest, with Imran revealing that the company has received multiple investment offers. His achievements have also earned him international recognition.

Imran has been selected for a prestigious global founders' programme associated with BlackRock, where only 60 young entrepreneurs from across the world have been chosen. The selection places him among a select group of emerging founders recognised globally for their innovation and entrepreneurial potential.

IMRAN REVEALED THAT THE COMPANY HAS RECEIVED MULTIPLE INVESTMENT OFFERS

Shree Arohan Chapter IV to put spotlight on young entrepreneurs

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Come July 11 and Shree Arohan Chapter IV- Annual Entrepreneurship Summit by Shikshayatan Entrepreneurship Society (SES), Shri Shikshayatan College, is all set to take over Kolkata. An initiative dedicated to fostering entrepreneurial thinking by bringing together aspiring founders, students, industry leaders, and innovators on one platform, Shree Arohan this year will have a footfall of more than 2,000 students from colleges across Kolkata. Millennium Post is the media partner for this prestigious annual entrepreneurship summit.

With the theme, 'Gotham: Rule the game before the city decides your fate', the event focuses on ethical business practices, innovation, and entrepreneurship. Inspired by the complexities of modern business, this year's theme explores the balance between ambition and ethics, encouraging participants to navigate the entrepreneurial landscape through innovation, strategic thinking, and responsible leadership.

One of the highlights of the event is the compelling panel discussion. This time, the panel discussion features Shashi Jain Dugar, an award-winning image consultant and leadership coach; Dr Priyanka Chatterjee (Golpo-didi), who is a TEDx speaker and internationally acclaimed storyteller and Suraj Juneja, a serial entrepreneur, startup mentor, and founder of Free-Flow Ventures.

How IIT Gandhinagar is rethinking engineering education

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Success for today's engineering students depends not just on what they learn in the lecture hall, but how well they apply that information in real-world scenarios. As engineering education evolves beyond the classroom, IIT Gandhinagar is enabling undergraduate students to spend an entire semester working in industry, research labs, academic institutions and startup ecosystems, and earn academic credits towards their degree.

IIT Gandhinagar's External Exposure Activity offers B.Tech students in the seventh semester an opportunity to gain hands-on experience with industries, research laboratories, academic institutions, start-up ecosystems and get



academic credits to fulfill their degree requirements. The institute integrates professional exposure in its curriculum and gives students an opportunity to get hands-on experience, develop industry-relevant skills and explore career paths before graduation.

The benefits are significant for

students. During this activity, students spend a semester in industry, research laboratories or start-ups, gaining exposure to workplace culture, working in teams, across disciplines and within real-world constraints. Such experiences help students make informed decisions about their future careers, higher education and entrepreneurial ambitions.

Since its introduction in the 2025-26 academic year, 18 students have participated in the programme, working with companies and research organisations such as Qualcomm, Solar Defence and Aerospace Limited, Tower Research Capital, Samsung R&D, Oracle, California Institute of Technology, and IISc Bangalore. Students have also undertaken external exposure at startups such as HapiHygi Innovations Pvt. Ltd.

Calcutta Boys' School's Concord 2026 concludes on a high note

30 SCHOOLS FROM ACROSS BENGAL PARTICIPATED IN THE THREE-DAY FEST

OUR CORRESPONDENT

The 44th edition of Concord 2026 organised by Calcutta Boys' School came to a vibrant end recently. Known as Kolkata's oldest and one of its most prestigious inter-school cultural festivals, the three-day event brings together the city's student community in a celebration of talent, creativity, and camaraderie. More than 30 reputed schools from across West Bengal participated in the three-day festival.

The festival was inaugurated with a welcome address by Raja McGee, Principal and Secretary of the Calcutta Boys' Group of Schools. Reflecting on the rich legacy of Concord, he described the festival as more than just a competition, calling it an inspiring platform that celebrates the spirit of camaraderie and provides young minds with an opportunity to learn, create, and grow together.

The opening ceremony was graced by renowned Tollywood actor Debleena Dutta, who attended as the chief guest. Recalling her previous visit to the school



HIGHLIGHTS

- » Champion: **CALCUTTA BOYS' SCHOOL**
- » First Runner-up: **LA MARTINIERE FOR BOYS'**
- » Second Runner-up: **ADAMAS INTERNATIONAL SCHOOL**



as a Concord participant, she spoke emotionally about returning to the festival. Addressing the students, she reminded them that, in the years to come, they would not remember whether they had won or lost; instead, they would cherish the memories they created and the pride of having taken part in the festival.

The opening day witnessed an impressive display of artistic and creative

talent across a range of events. In the Devotional Choir competition, Garden High School captivated the audience with a soulful and confident performance. La Martiniere for Boys delivered a high-energy presentation in the Instrumental event, earning enthusiastic applause from the audience.

The day also featured competitions such as poster making, comic strip, and

console gaming, providing students with opportunities to showcase their artistic flair, imagination, and competitive spirit beyond the performing arts.

Interestingly, the grand finale was held at the EZCC, Kolkata, with acclaimed Bengali actor Soumya Mukherjee gracing the occasion as the chief guest. The concluding ceremony began with captivating dance performances by

participating schools, followed by a spectacular tribute to Michael Jackson presented by the students of Calcutta Boys' School.

The celebrations reached their peak with an energetic live performance by the popular band In-Sync, whose vibrant music had the audience singing, cheering, and dancing together in a fitting finale to the festival.

IIT MADRAS' NEURODIVERSITY SUMMIT A HIT



Aims to create an inclusive ecosystem

OUR CORRESPONDENT

IIT Madras hosted Neurodiversity Summit 2026 recently on the campus, which brought together in one platform the researchers, NGOs, industry leaders, policymakers and community stakeholders. The aim was to develop a collaborative roadmap for creating an inclusive ecosystem that empowers neurodivergent individuals through research, innovation and community partnerships.

The summit had the theme of 'Research, Innovation and Community for Inclusive Futures'. It marked an important step towards building scalable, technology-enabled and community-driven solutions that address the lifelong needs of neurodivergent individuals across learning, employment and independent living.

Establishing a Centre of Excellence for Neurodiversity at IIT Madras was a focus of the summit. The proposed Centre will drive research and innovation in digital assessment tools, personalised assistive technologies, adaptive vocational solutions and capacity building, while serving as a hub for collaborative research, technology translation and community engagement.

Organised by IIT Madras faculty members in collabora-

tion with the Institute's ACR Office, the summit showcased a multidisciplinary approach, with experts from Management Studies, Mechanical Engineering, Applied Mechanics, Biotechnology, Humanities and other disciplines working alongside leading NGOs and civil society.

THE PLATFORM IS EXPECTED TO FACILITATE COLLABORATIVE RESEARCH, EVIDENCE-BASED ADVOCACY AND THE DEVELOPMENT OF POLICY-READY INDICATORS THAT PROMOTE INCLUSION

"I have five priority areas for this Neurodiversity Centre of Excellence, starting with neurodiversity for which we need early identification. The technology development has to be a priority. We need employment pathways that move beyond tokenism. We should identify specific employment opportunities for people with disabilities," said Prof V Kamakoti, Director, IIT Madras.



ADMISSION ALERT

BSc Honours from Nagaland University

Applications open till July 15, 2026

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Nagaland University is inviting applications for admission to its Four-Year Undergraduate Programme (FYUGP) in BSc for the 2026-27 academic session through CUET-UG 2026.

The admissions will be conducted by the University's Multi-Disciplinary Research



THE ONLINE APPLICATION PROCESS WILL REMAIN OPEN TILL JULY 15, 2026

Centre (MDRC) in accordance with the NEP 2020 framework.

The UG programme offers students the flexibility to pursue Honours and Honours with Research programmes in five science disciplines—Botany, Chemistry, Mathematics, Physics, and Zoology.

Admissions will be granted strictly on merit based on candidates' CUET-UG scores and Class XII examination performance, as per the eligibility criteria prescribed by the respective academic departments.